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The Construction of China's National Image from
the Perspective of Multimodal Discourse Analysis:

A Case Study of *China on the Move (Season 2)*

中国国家形象的多模态构建研究

——以《行进中的中国》第二季为例

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**The Construction of China's National Image from
the Perspective of Multimodal Discourse Analysis:
*A Case Study of China on the Move (Season 2)***

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摘要

随着全球化深入发展和多模态话语分析的兴起，外宣纪录片在传播国家故事和塑造国家形象方面发挥着关键作用。中外合拍纪录片《行进中的中国》（第二季）通过创新性的国际化视听语言与中国叙事体系的有机融合，为中国特色国际传播构建提供了重要案例支撑。本研究以多模态话语分析为理论框架，旨在探讨纪录片《行进中的中国》第二季塑造了怎样的国家形象。

本研究以 Halliday 的系统功能语法、Kress and van Leeuwen 的视觉语法、张德禄的多模态协同理论为理论框架，选取纪录片《行进中的中国》第二季第 5 集为研究材料，Elan 6.9 和 UAM Corpus Tool 6 为标注工具，采用定性和定量相结合的研究方法分析纪录片中的语言模态和视觉模态是如何建构意义的，然后用定性的方法探讨模态协同塑造的国家形象。

研究发现，第一，从模态分析的视角来看，本研究主要从语言模态和视觉模态对纪录片进行分析，就语言模态而言，该纪录片在概念意义层面主要使用物质过程向世界展示中国改善民生的实践，详细介绍了中国的乡村振兴和发展成果；在人际意义层面，陈述句和低情态动词的高频使用表明纪录片在语言上强调信息的客观性和真实性，同时以一种谦逊的方式展现国家成就。就视觉模态而言，动作过程占比最高表明纪录片倾向于通过画面展现中国在民生改善的实际行动和成就；在互动意义层面，该纪录片主要采用提供型信息，通过中景加远景镜头的结合，将宏大主题融入个体叙事，客观呈现了中国人民共享发展成果的具体实践和成效；在构图意义层面，纪录片主要运用中心-边缘和显著性来突出重点信息。第二，从模态协同关系的维度来看，该纪录片中语言模态和视觉模态主要呈现出互补关系中的非强化关系，这种模态协同在多模态叙事与情感体验的双重维度上增强了国家形象传播的效果。第三，从国家形象塑造的层面来看，概念意义和再现意义中的过程构成了中国国家形象的核心要素，而参与者路径则系统性地体现了国家形象的多维特征，通过国民、政府、社会三个维度的协同建构，形成了多维度的国家形象体系。具体而言，纪录片通过文字模态中的物质和心理过程等，结合视觉模态中的动作和分类等过程，共同构建了人民幸福富足、政府高效有为、社会团结奋进的立体化国家形象；同时，伴随环境成分和过程的使用，进一步强化了中国社会团结奋进的形象。

摘要

本研究基于多模态话语分析理论框架，通过系统分析语言模态与视觉模态的表征特征及其协同关系，深入探究了纪录片话语中国国家形象的建构，为新时代中国对外传播与国家形象塑造提供了一定的启示；同时验证了从多模态话语分析角度解读动态多模态语篇的可行性，拓宽了多模态话语分析的研究领域。

关键词：《行进中的中国》（第二季）；国家形象；系统功能语法；视觉语法

Abstract

With the deepening of globalization and the rise of multimodal discourse analysis, publicity documentaries play a vital role in communicating national stories and shaping the national image. The co-produced documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)*, through its innovative integration of international audiovisual language with Chinese narrative systems, provides crucial case support for constructing international communication with Chinese characteristics. This study, grounded in the theoretical framework of multimodal discourse analysis, aims to explore what national images the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)* constructs.

This study adopts Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar, Kress and van Leeuwen's Visual Grammar, and Zhang Delu's multimodal synergy theory as the theoretical foundation. This thesis selects episode 5 of *China on the Move (Season 2)* as the research material with Elan 6.9 and UAM Corpus Tool 6 as annotation tools. It combines the qualitative and quantitative research methods to analyze how verbal and visual modalities construct meaning. Subsequently, a qualitative approach is employed to further explore the national image shaped through modal synergy.

It has been found that, first, the study mainly analyzes the verbal and visual modalities in the documentary. In terms of the verbal modality, the documentary mostly uses material processes to show the world China's practice of improving people's livelihood at the level of ideational function and introduce China's rural revitalization and achievements in detail. At the level of the interpersonal function, the high proportion of declarative sentences and low modal verbs suggests that the documentary focuses on the objectivity and authenticity of information in its language while humbly presenting the country's achievements. In terms of visual modality, the highest proportion of the action processes indicates that the documentary tends to show China's practical actions and achievements in improving people's livelihoods through video. At the level of interactive meaning, the documentary integrates the grand theme into the individual narrative through the combination of medium and long shots and objectively

presents the concrete practices and achievements of the Chinese people's sharing of development achievements. At the level of the compositional meaning, the documentary mainly uses center-margin structure and salience to highlight key information. Second, in terms of modality synergy, the most important relationship between the verbal and visual modalities is the non-reinforced relationship in the complementary relationship, and modality synergy strengthens the effectiveness of national image communication in the dual dimensions of multimodal narrative and emotional experience. Third, from the perspective of national image construction, the processes within ideational and representational meanings constitute the core elements of China's national image, while the participant pathways reflect the multidimensional characteristics of the national image. Through the coordinated construction of three dimensions- the people, the government, and society- a multi-dimensional national image system is formed. Specifically, the documentary employs material and mental processes in the verbal modality, combined with action and classification processes in the visual modality, to construct a three-dimensional national image characterized by the happy and prosperous people, the efficient and capable government, and the united and progressive society. Furthermore, the accompanying circumstances and processes further reinforces the overall image of a united and progressive Chinese society.

This study, based on the theoretical framework of multimodal discourse analysis, systematically examines the representational features of both verbal and visual modalities and their interactive mechanisms, thereby investigating the construction of national image in documentary. The research provides some insights into China's international communication practices and national image-building in the new era. Furthermore, it affirms the feasibility of interpreting dynamic multimodal discourse from the perspective of multimodal discourse analysis, thereby expanding the research field of multimodal discourse analysis.

Key Words: *China on the Move (Season 2)*; National Image; Systemic Functional Grammar; Visual Grammar

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Chapter One Introduction

This chapter systematically elaborates on the research background, thoroughly analyzes its theoretical significance and practical value, proposes specific research questions and research methodologies, and outlines the structure of the thesis.

1.1 Research Background

With the rapid development of digital technology and profound transformation of human communication methods, multimodal discourse has become a distinctive feature of modern discourse systems. This shift profoundly influences the way humans transmit information. The practice of multimodal discourse has become more abundant and diversified and has become the new norm of communication. The meaning of a discourse is not produced by a single linguistic sign but is often produced by the interaction and synergy of linguistic and nonlinguistic signs (Roland Barthes, 1977).

As a typical multimodal discourse, the documentary organically combined image, text, sound, music, and other modes to transmit information. Wang Lu and Lai Hanyi (2022) believed that documentaries mainly present content through image, music, voice, subtitles and other information transmission modes, among which images are the most intuitive expression of content. In the multimodal system of documentaries, the verbal and visual modalities constitute the core modal system with the most significant representational functions.

In the current global media landscape, western media have long dominated discourse power. International audiences lack objective channels to understand China's policy philosophy and development practices, making it difficult to form comprehensive and rational assessments. Against this backdrop, documentaries, with their authentic visual narratives that balance objectivity and artistic expression, serve as a powerful medium to vividly showcase China's developmental achievements, cultural heritage, and social vitality, effectively dismantling cognitive barriers in the international community.

To meet the 20th National Congress, the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)* emerged. As a topic for the “Record China” communication project of the Publicity Department of the Communist Party of China Central Committee and the “14th Five-Year Plan” documentary of the State Administration of Radio, this documentary is of great significance to the external communication of China’s image. This documentary encompasses five themes, including China’s system, economy, science and technology innovation, ecology, and people’s livelihood. The research object of this thesis, Episode 5, centers on the theme of people’s livelihoods. Initially, it delves into the issue of poverty alleviation, highlighting China’s comprehensive victory in the battle against poverty. Subsequently, it illustrates how China enhances the living conditions of migrant workers. Lastly, the documentary reveals the new forms of employment in China as well as the continuous improvement of the employment environment and social security. These cases collectively present a multifaceted and vivid representation of China’s contemporary narrative.

Given these factors, investigating how national image is constructed in the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)* proves to be academically significant. The research focuses on the verbal and visual modalities in the documentary and explores their relation and the national image constructed in the documentary.

1.2 Research Purpose and Significance

With the advancement of economic globalization and the proliferation of multimedia technologies, the export and exchange of cultural assets among nations have intensified in frequency. Consequently, documentaries have emerged as important channels for cultural export. This thesis aims to investigate the national image shaped by the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)* by integrating the Systemic Functional Grammar of Halliday (1994) and the Visual Grammar of Kress and van Leeuwen (1996). Multimodal discourse analysis plays a crucial role in analyzing and understanding the documentary as a multimodal form.

Theoretical and practical values are illustrated as follows: from the theoretical perspective, most of the existing research focuses on the visual modal analysis in static

discourse, but relatively little research explores the verbal modality and modality synergy in dynamic discourse. Therefore, this study extends the analytical boundaries of multimodal discourse analysis (MDA) while contributing perspectives to the examination of national image in publicity documentary. Furthermore, it validates the practical utility of MDA in dynamic visual narratives. Practically speaking, the thesis first systematically analyzes the verbal and visual modalities in the documentary, which helps deconstruct its meanings and offers the global audience deeper insights into the opportunities and challenges China faces. This study conducts an in-depth analysis of the modal features and meaning-making processes in the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)*, aiming to reveal how multimodal discourse systematically configures semiotic resources to successfully construct an authentic, three-dimensional, and comprehensive national image of China. The research ultimately seeks to achieve effective dissemination and identity construction of the national image through multimodal discourse analysis.

1.3 Research Questions

The purpose of this thesis is to explore the national image through the verbal and visual modalities and their interactive mechanisms in the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)*. Based on the proposed analytical framework, the research examines the verbal and visual modalities and explores the national image constructed in the documentary.

Within the framework of multimodal discourse analysis, the research intends to explore the following questions:

1. How do the verbal and visual modalities of *China on the Move (Season 2)* construct meaning respectively?
2. What are the relationships between verbal and visual modalities?
3. What national images do *China on the Move (Season 2)* establish?

1.4 Research Methodology

This study integrates both qualitative and quantitative methods. With the help of the UAM Corpus Tool 6 and Elan 6.9, the distribution of textual processes and visual structures are objectively identified and analyzed. The thesis selects the episode 5 as the research material, which is about 24 minutes and contains subtitles, voice-over, images and so on. The verbal modality of the documentary comprises 2,952 tokens. Because the features of different modalities, the multimodal analysis of *China on the Move (Season 2)* will be carried out by the following steps:

Firstly, the UAM Corpus Tool 6 is utilized to annotate the text in terms of the verbal modality. This study initiates its analytical process by systematically importing textual data into the project, followed by an annotation procedure based on the transitivity system within systemic functional grammar. The annotation scheme meticulously identifies and categorizes six process types. Then, qualitative research is utilized to analyze the verbal modality. Drawing on Halliday's systemic functional grammar (SFG), the thesis examines the realization of meta-functions of the verbal modality.

Secondly, the study employs Elan 6.9 for the annotation and analysis of the visual modality with the guide of visual grammar. The percentage of six types of representational processes is conducted, which aims to reveal the predominant strategies in visual representation. The research investigates the interactive meaning through two key parameters: the proportional distribution of offer and demand images and the proportion of different frame sizes. Subsequently, visual grammar is applied to investigate the realization of the visual images. Qualitative analysis is applied to conduct a detailed analysis of specific shots to analyze the meaning conveyed.

Finally, guided by Zhang Delu's theoretical framework of multimodal synergy, the research explores the dynamic interaction between verbal and visual semiotic resources, examining their collaborative mechanisms in meaning construction. Then, the thesis investigates what national images of China are presented.

This thesis employs two specialized software tools, ELAN (version 6.9) and UAM Corpus Tool (version 6), to conduct a multimodal analysis of the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)*. ELAN, which can be downloaded from the website:

<https://archive.mpi.nl/tla/elan>, serves as a professional audio-visual annotation tool. It is capable of achieving millisecond-level precision in multimodal synchronous annotation, supporting unlimited text annotation tiers, making it particularly suitable for processing visual and other multimodal elements in documentaries. Meanwhile, UAM Corpus Tool (version 6.9), which can be downloaded from the website: <http://www.corpustool.com/index.html>, functions as an advanced corpus analysis environment focused on three-dimensional annotation in systemic functional linguistics. These two tools form a complementary analytical chain—ELAN 6.9 handles the multimodal segmentation and annotation of raw materials, while UAM 6 performs in-depth functional discourse analysis and statistical validation. This collaborative analytical approach not only ensures precise capture of multimodal features but also meets the specific requirements for analyzing documentary multimodal discourse, providing a reliable methodological foundation for understanding how documentaries construct national image through multimodal collaboration.

1.5 Organization of the Thesis

This thesis consists of five parts.

Chapter One is an introduction. It presents the research background, research purpose and significance, research questions, research methodology, and the general structure of the thesis.

Chapter Two serves as a review of previous studies. It reviews the previous theoretical and applied studies on multimodal discourse analysis. Then, it also introduces previous studies on documentaries from the perspective of MDA and the previous study on China's national image. The previous studies prove the necessity of the present study.

Chapter Three is the theoretical foundation. Three main theories are introduced in detail: they are systemic functional grammar, visual grammar, and Zhang Delu's multimodal synergy. Based on these theories, a framework for the present research is proposed.

Chapter Four constitutes the core analytical component of this thesis, providing a comprehensive examination of verbal and visual modalities from MDA. The last part is the synthetic analysis of the two modalities to explore their relation and the analysis of the national image.

Chapter Five is the conclusion. It summarizes the research findings, implications, and limitations of the thesis and gives suggestions for further study in the field.

Chapter Two Literature Review

2.1 Previous Studies on MDA

2.1.1 Previous Theoretical Studies on MDA

Since the 1960s, structuralist semioticians of the Paris School have utilized linguistic concepts and methodologies to investigate modes of communication beyond language. Researchers are increasingly aware that language is one of the means of meaning generation, and image is also the symbolic mode of meaning generation, making research into a new field of Multimodal Discourse Analysis (MDA). The MDA flourished in the 1990s, marked by the publication of two seminal works: *The Language of Displayed Art* (O'Toole, 1994) and *Reading Images: The Grammar of Visual Design* (Kress and van Leeuwen, 1996). These publications sparked a surge of interest in MDA among international linguistics. Building on their contributions, an increasing number of scholars have engaged in developing both theoretical frameworks and practical applications within this area of study. In the field of linguistics, the study of multimodal discourse is still mainly developed along the two theoretical perspectives of Systemic Functional Linguistics and Cognitive Linguistics (Wu Yuxi and Zhao Xiufeng, 2022).

Multimodal discourse theory is still dominated by social semiotics. Its theoretical framework is mainly rooted in SFG (Li Mengjie et al., 2024). For instance, O'Toole (1994) was the first to apply this research approach to the multimodal discourse analysis of displayed art. Norris (2004) designed a methodological framework to study people's interactions. O'Halloran (2008) worked out ways to multimodal discourse analysis in mathematics textbooks. Painter et al. (2014) further proposed the four systems of focalization, pathos, ambience, and gradation based on Kress and van Leeuwen's (1996) framework of interactive meaning and mood. Bateman and Wildfeuer (2014) proposed a general pragmatic model for visual narrative analysis, offering a unified framework for visual and linguistic communication. Martin and

Unsworth (2023) proposed a socio-semiotics framework for analyzing the knowledge construction process of visual resources in subject teaching and learning.

Besides, multimodal discourse analysis has been studied from the cognitive perspective, focusing on metaphor and metonymy in discourse. The study of multimodal metaphor (Forceville, 1996; Forceville and Urios-Aparisi, 2009) mainly discussed the textual characteristics of multimodal metaphor but did not study the systematic characteristics. From the perspective of cognitive linguistics, Hart (2016) pointed out that previous visual experience plays an important role in the construction of linguistic meaning and believed that multimodal analysis can help fully explain linguistic meaning to reduce the subjectivity of researchers' interpretation of linguistic meaning.

Domestic studies on MDA have experienced substantial theoretical progression through successive scholarly contributions. The foundational work by Li Zhanzi (2003) pioneered the examination of social semiotic resources within MDA. Hu Zhuanglin (2007) systematically contrasted multimodal and multimedia approaches to meaning-making while forecasting the emergence of a new era focusing on multimodality. Zhu Yongsheng (2007) systematically delineated the concepts of this approach, its development, theoretical constructs, and methodology, which further expanded the research scope. Wei Qinhong's investigation (2008) applied systemic functional grammar to analyze multimodal texts from *The Times*, demonstrating the potential of non-linguistic semiotic systems, including color, auditory signals, and visual representations in communication. Subsequently, in the 2009 theoretical work, Wei Qinhong provided crucial conceptual differentiation between three fundamental concepts, which are mode, medium, and modality, offering Chinese researchers a more targeted understanding of core theoretical concepts in this field. Zeng Fangben (2008) identified potential challenges in multimodal discourse interpretation, suggesting that the convergence of various communicative modes could potentially result in interpretive ambiguities. Zhang Delu (2009a) proposed a theoretical framework of multimodal research and also discussed the interrelationship between various modes. Xu Guohong and Qu Hang (2009) conducted an in-depth historical examination of multimodal research development, providing an extensive overview of key theoretical

contributions within this research domain. Wu Yuanzheng and Feng Dezheng (2022) proposed a multi-modal ecological discourse analysis framework based on attitudinal meaning by integrating the evaluation system and visual grammar.

2.1.2 Previous Applied Studies on MDA

Recent years have witnessed a substantial growth in applied studies employing multimodal analytical frameworks, surpassing theoretical explorations in both quantity and scope. First, many scholars focus on the MDA in the media works from the SFG. Zheng Qun and Zhang Bo (2015) analyzed the covers in *The Economist* with visual grammar (VG) as the theoretical framework. Xu Yinxue (2016) presented three swan feather scenes, respectively, from the three meanings of visual grammar. And Chen Shujun and Wei Zaijiang (2024) explored the discourse features of constructive news, drawing on the SFG and cognitive linguistics. Qi Wenjin (2024) conducted a comprehensive analysis of the visual semiotic resources of the five tourism types from the official Beijing tourism website.

Second, multimodal translation and communication is also a popular research theme in MDA. Research objects can be divided into classics and dynamic videos. For instance, Wang Zhiguo and Chu Yinjuan (2021) took Chinese original picture books as the research object, probed into the strategies of the English translation of Chinese picture books. Han Ziman and Huang Guangzhe (2023) studied the performative translation of the Chinese classic *Zhuangzi*. Lin Yi (2023) discussed multimodal translation based on the novel. In terms of the documentary, Wu Jianguo and Cui Yuqing (2024), based on rural revitalization documentaries, discussed the multimodal context reconstruction strategies and translation principles applicable to the translation of Chinese rural revitalization documentaries.

Third, the application of multimodal approaches in education has attracted considerable scholars' attention in recent years. Unsworth et al. (2022) constructed a framework for multimodal disciplinary literacy based on social semiotics and systemic functional linguistics, aiming at guiding the practice of teaching and learning in high school subjects. Gu Yueguo (2007) outlined an analytic model for multimedia learning and multimodal learning. In his 2008 study, Zhu Yongsheng explored the impact of

multiple semiotic resources on pedagogical innovation. This has been further developed by other scholars who utilized multimodal frameworks to enhance English language instruction. Zhang Delu's (2009b) theoretical framework offered practical recommendations for selecting appropriate instructional strategies and classroom activities in technology-mediated language education contexts. Zhang Zheng (2013) revealed a significant relationship between PowerPoint materials and learners' motivational levels. Notably, Zhang Changjie (2015) proposed the concept of multimodal metaphorical representation, offering teachers practical strategies for leveraging various communicative ways to develop learners' writing proficiency. Kang Zhifeng et al. (2023) demonstrated that ideological and political education can be effectively merged into multi-modal interpreting courses. Furthermore, research evidence has substantiated the pedagogical value of strategically employing multimodal resources for enhancing English language acquisition. Zhang Yihua (2024) explored how to utilize multimodal semiotic resources to construct a multimodal lexicon of paraphrase patterns based on large language models and multimodal discourse analysis.

Multimodal discourse theory is still dominated by social semiotics, and most applied research focuses on the fields of multimodal teaching and translation. A notable characteristic in the multimodal discourse studies lies in its theoretical synthesis, encompassing both intradisciplinary linguistic frameworks and cross-disciplinary theoretical paradigms. In conclusion, there is still more research on static text and relatively less on dynamic multimodal in China.

2.2 Previous Studies on Publicity Documentaries

As an artistic genre of recording objective reality, the documentary is an important medium of cultural communication. At present, domestic research on publicity documentaries from the perspective of MDA encompasses a broad spectrum of aspects, which can be categorized into three primary dimensions:

The first kind of research focuses on multimodal discourse analysis of the documentaries. Liu Yu and Zhang Hongjun (2018) focused on the documentaries and

national image from the perspective of communication. Yuan Xiaolu and Nai Ruihua (2022) developed an analytical framework for MDA through their examination of the BBC documentary titled *Chinese New Year: The Biggest Celebration on Earth*. Their research aimed to establish a methodological approach for enhancing the international communication of the Cultural China narrative. Sun Ju (2023) focused on the multimodal discourse analysis of patriotism in *Together Against COVID-19*. Zhao Guangying (2023) took the documentary *Festival China* as a research object to explore the expression and construction process of its multimodal discourse.

The second research kind examines documentary translation through the multimodal theory. Considerable scholarly attention has been directed toward analyzing audiovisual translation, particularly in television productions, utilizing multimodal frameworks. Xin Hongjuan (2020) proposed a multimodal discourse translation analysis model of contextualization, synchronization, systematization, and integration, focusing on the typical translation method of Xinhua News Agency's documentary, *Four Seasons of China*. Wu Jianguo et al. (2021) studied multimodal translation in documentaries and national image. Wang Lu and Lai Hanyi (2022) discussed diverse translation strategies for translating cultural-loaded words. Wang Honglin (2024) selected the Chinese and English logos and visual symbols of the publicity documentary *Zhejiang China* to study their intertextuality from the perspective of multimodal transformation.

The third kind focuses on the metaphor and metonymy phenomena in the documentary from the multimodal discourse and explores their important roles in meaning construction. Pan Yanyan (2013) pointed out that there are many complex interactions between conceptual metaphor and metonymy, and modal metaphor and metonymy achieve coherence and depth in the construction of meaning through the synergistic interaction of images, words, music, and other modes. Pan Yanyan (2017) made a multimodal cognitive critical analysis of Chinese and American military recruitment publicity videos and revealed the differences in narrative mode, discourse strategy, and ideology. Li Xue and Yang Yuanjie (2022) interpreted the metaphor and metonymy phenomena and their meaning construction in advertising video and discussed how the video achieves the narrative function of China's image construction.

Based on the theory of multimodal metaphorical meaning construction, Shen Chuanli and Liu Xingbing (2022) analyzed the types of conceptual metaphors used in environmental promotional videos and the ecological views conveyed. Song Haibo (2022) conducted a multimodal metaphor analysis of the animation scenes.

Current research has established a relatively mature methodological framework for multimodal analysis of documentaries, primarily focusing on three dimensions: multimodal discourse construction mechanisms, cross-modal translation strategies, and meaning generation through metaphor and metonymy. However, these studies exhibit three limitations: First, the analysis predominantly concentrates on representative successful cases, lacking reflective research on communication failures. Second, the research methods are primarily text-based, with no established empirical evaluation framework for audience cognitive effects. Third, the research perspective largely remains at the production end, seldom examining the actual decoding processes of international audiences. While this study acknowledges similar limitations in empirical audience data, it introduces refined multimodal annotation using ELAN 6.9 and UAM 6 software to provide more precise research for constructing national image in documentaries.

2.3 Previous Studies on National Image

The study of the national image began in the 1950s, mostly related to the concepts of national interest, prestige, and reputation. Some scholars believe that national image contributes to the formulation of foreign policy and can correctly evaluate international cooperation and conflicts. The purpose of constructing a national image is to pursue the prestige of a country in international relations, get the recognition of other countries, and establish a good image.

The American scholar Boulding (1959) provided a clear definition of the national image that the image must be thought of as the total cognitive, affective, and evaluative structure of the behavior unit, or its internal view of itself and its universe. Wang Ning (2018) argued that the perception of China and its people in western perspectives has undergone significant transformation over time. In the international society, China's

portrayal has shifted from being recognized primarily as an ancient civilization to being viewed as a socialist country. The image change not only affects the international community's view of China but also may further affect China's international status and development trend. Therefore, the national image is an important content that cannot be ignored in China's development.

Since its conceptual emergence, the construction of the national image has generated substantial academic debate across various disciplines. More and more scholars have explored the "national image" from two aspects: self-evaluation and other evaluation in media communication. Several researchers have investigated portrayals of China's national identity in both domestic and foreign press.

For previous studies on China Image in new discourse, the research on national image can be divided into self-shaping and other-shaping studies according to the subject. From the self-shaping perspective, the objects of study involve documentaries, movies, news reports, white papers, and so on. For example, Chen Fachun (2023) discussed China's image and word choices in the English version of the Report to the 20th National Congress of the CPC. From other shaping perspectives, many scholars argue about our national image in the Western media. Zhang Yu and Liu Siwen (2021) took Twitter, a mainstream social networking platform in Western countries, as the research object to investigate the image of China among the foreign audience and found that the vast majority of Americans have always held a negative attitude toward China. Zuo Tingting and Zhao Yunmei (2023) analyzed the national image constructed from the perspective of mainstream English media in Thailand. And many scholars focused on the comparative study. Hu Xiaobin (2021) employed a multidimensional analytical approach supported by corpus linguistics to contrast portrayals of China's pandemic response between Chinese and American news press. Men Chaoyuan (2024) employed a critical discourse analysis perspective and used corpus tools to conduct a comparative analysis of the language strategies for constructing national images.

Domestic scholars have made significant progress in investigating the representation of China's national images. However, current research primarily focuses on three types: misrepresentation in international media coverage, comparative analyses of cross-cultural reports, or domestic Chinese media works, while paying

insufficient attention to co-produced documentaries for national image construction. Furthermore, most scholars tend to concentrate predominantly on visual modality when studying the documentaries, often neglecting the role of other modalities and their interrelationships. Therefore, this study takes *China on the Move (Season 2)*, co-produced by China and the Discovery Channel, as its research object. By integrating systemic functional grammar and visual grammar, the research analyzes how the verbal and visual modalities in the documentary construct meaning with the help of Elan 6.9 and UAM Corpus Tool 6. Furthermore, it explores the interactive relationship between these two modalities and what national images they collaboratively build.

Chapter Three Theoretical Foundation

3.1 Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar

Systemic functional grammar was created and developed by linguist M.A.K. Halliday based on the linguistic ideas of the London School. As one of the most significant linguistic frameworks developed in the twentieth century, Systemic Functional Linguistics serves as the foundational theory for multimodal discourse studies. It comprises two complementary components: the systemic approach, which conceptualizes language as a network of interrelated systems, and the functional perspective, which examines language use in social contexts. "System is the paradigmatic ordering in language. Any set of alternatives, together with its condition of entry, constitutes a system in this technical sense" (Halliday, 2014: 22). Functional grammar focuses on revealing that language functions as a tool for social interaction. The position and forms of language are fundamentally shaped by the communicative purposes they fulfill. These two parts form an integrated theoretical framework. In Halliday's (1994) framework, language fulfills its communicative purposes through three interdependent functional components: ideational, interpersonal, and textual.

3.1.1 The Ideational Function

Halliday's ideational function encompasses two distinct components: the experiential and logical functions (Hu Zhuanglin, 2017). This meta-function serves to transmit information and share unfamiliar content with the audience. Within this framework, the primary grammatical systems that realize the ideational meaning are transitivity and voice systems. The transitivity system serves as a semantic framework that organizes human experiences into distinct "processes" by analyzing what individuals perceive, hear, and perform in the real world. Through this system, different experiences are classified, with associated "participants" and "circumstantial elements" being identified for each type of process. This system enables the categorization of human experiences into six primary processes: material, mental, relational, behavioral,

verbal, and existential. The material process represents a process of doing something. This process is typically expressed by dynamic verbs while the “Actor” and the “Goal” of the action are usually represented by nouns. The mental process represents psychological activities such as perception, reaction, and cognition. A mental process typically involves two participants. One is the subject of the psychological activity, known as the “Senser,” and the other is the object, referred to as the “Phenomenon”, which is the entity being perceived, reacted to, or cognized. The relational process refers to a process of being that reflects the relationships between things. Relational processes can be divided into two main categories: attributive and identifying. A behavioral process refers to a process of physical activity. The behavioral process generally has only one participant, the “Behaver”, and the one acting is usually a person. The verbal process is the process of communicating information through speech. A “Verbiage” may be a message to be delivered to the addressee. An existential process is a process of existing. In every existence, there is an Existent.

Circumstantial components maintain consistent semantic value across various process types within the transitivity system. These components are examined through three analytical dimensions: semantic function (answering “when, where, how, why”), syntactic role (functioning as Adjuncts rather than Subjects), and grammatical realization (typically through adverbial constructions or, more frequently, prepositional phrases). The classification of circumstantial adjuncts includes categories such as Extent, Location, Manner, Cause, and Accompaniment. Among these, Accompaniment serves as a co-participant in the process, expressing conjunctive meaning through circumstantial realization.

3.1.2 The Interpersonal Function

Within the framework of interpersonal meaning, language serves as a tool for social engagement, enabling speakers to construct relationships, convey affective states, and shape participants’ perspectives and actions (Thompson, 2008). The interpersonal function is realized by mood and modality.

The mood system reflects the communicative roles adopted by participants in verbal interactions, comprising two essential grammatical components: the subject and finite elements. Modality expresses the speaker's assessment regarding the validity of propositions, the degree of obligation in directives, or the level of commitment in suggestions. (Halliday, 1994). In the mood system, language can be used to affirm or deny, but also to doubt, refute, and insist. Therefore, language plays a variety of roles in communicating with people. People have three main choices: First, use the declarative mood to describe something; Second, use imperative sentences to command or ask people to do or stop doing something. The third is to ask questions. The modality system refers to the meaning area between "yes" and "no" because there are many intermediate levels between the two. So, there are three different modal values: high, medium, and low values.

3.1.3 The Textual Function

The textual function encompasses linguistic mechanisms that transform discourse into coherent, unified texts, distinguishing meaningful communication from the disconnected sentence sequences. This function uses language to link other pieces of language. Halliday (2004) identifies three primary realizations of this function: thematic organization, informational patterning, and cohesive devices. Within functional syntax, thematic structure plays a crucial role, consisting of two components: the point of departure (theme) and the developing message (rheme). Thematic elements are classified as unmarked when coinciding with grammatical subjects and marked when realized through other syntactic constituents.

3.2 Kress and van Leeuwen's Visual Grammar

Visual grammar is employed frequently as the theoretical framework to examine the visual elements in multimodal discourses. Building on Halliday's SFG, Kress and van Leeuwen (1996) expanded the theory, positing that images serve as social symbols and tools for meaning interpretation, much like language. Visual images not only depict the objective world but also convey human relationships. Their work introduced visual

grammar (VG) and established a detailed framework for the analysis of visual representations. These scholars contended that visual images, along with other semiotic systems like language, perform three meta-functions: representation, interaction, and composition.

Table 3.1 Three meta-functions in SFG and three meanings in VG

SFG	VG
Ideational Function	Representational Meaning
Interpersonal Function	Interactive Meaning
Textual Function	Compositional Meaning

3.2.1 Representational Meaning

The representational meaning aligns with the concept of ideational meaning. Visual image representation encompasses two distinct types: narrative and conceptual structures. “When participants are connected by a vector, they are represented as doing something to or for each other. From here on we will call such vectorial patterns narrative” (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2006: 59). In contrast, the conceptual representations depict participants in terms of their inherent qualities, such as class and structure. A key distinction between the two lies in the presence of vectors: narrative structures inherently involve vectors, while conceptual structures do not. Furthermore, narrative processes can be categorized based on the nature of the vectors and the types and quantities of participants involved.

Narrative Structures serve to depict various facets of reality through the portrayal of unfolding actions and events and processes of change (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2021). Narrative patterns can be further subdivided into processes and circumstances. The primary processes consist of action, reactional, speech and mental processes. Within the action process, the Actor is defined as the figure from which the directional vector emerges. If the vector is generated by the eyeline of the figures, the structure is categorized as the reactional process. In such cases, the Actor is referred to as the Reacter while the Goal is termed the Phenomenon. “Vectors in speech and mental

process are primarily constructed through the link between the participant and the thought bubble or the dialogue bubble” (Kress and van Leeuwen, 1996). Conceptual representation tends to be more enduring and less influenced by temporal or spatial factors. This category can be further divided into the classificational, analytical, and symbolic processes.

3.2.2 Interactive Meaning

“Visual communication also has resources for constituting and maintaining another kind of interaction, the interaction between the producer and the viewer of the image” (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2006: 114). The visual mode must effectively convey the relationship between the producers and their viewers. It is established through four primary systems: contact, social distance, attitude, and modality.

Contact refers to an imagined relationship between the depicted figures and the audience, divided into two types: “demand” and “offer”. In a “demand” picture, a direct gaze is formed between the participants and observers, fostering a sense of involvement and interaction. “Offer” arises when no direct gaze is present, yet contact is conveyed to the audience via other visual components. (Kress and van Leeuwen, 1996).

Social distance determines the distance between the participants and the viewers, related to the choice between close-up, medium and long shot. For instance, a close-up shot typically suggests a closer, more personal connection, whereas a long shot implies detachment or formality. (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2006).

Attitude is conveyed through the selection of an angle and a point of view, which includes both horizontal and vertical angles. A frontal horizontal angle immerses the viewer in the scene, fostering a sense of involvement, while an oblique angle may create a feeling of detachment or indifference. Vertically, a high angle positions the viewer in a dominant stance, whereas a low angle empowers the image participants. An eye-level angle, however, suggests equality and neutrality between the participants and the viewers (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2006).

Modality plays a crucial role in assessing the realism or credibility of the visual world depicted in images. It serves as a measure of the truth value or plausibility

conveyed by visual representations. Modality is categorized into three levels: high, medium, and low. These levels are determined through modality markers, which include color saturation, differentiation, and modulation. (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2006). In systemic functional grammar, modality is defined as the semantic framework through which language users assess the likelihood of events and express their stance on the obligation of those events (Zhu Yongsheng, 2007).

3.2.3 Compositional Meaning

Visual grammar provides a variety of compositional ways that the elements are integrated into a meaningful whole. The three primary principles in compositional meaning are information value, salience, and framing. Typically, elements positioned on the left side represent given or familiar information, whereas those on the right convey new or unfamiliar content. Similarly, the upper section of an image often symbolizes idealized or generalized concepts, while the lower section tends to depict concrete or factual details. In terms of spatial organization, Kress and van Leeuwen argue that central placement signifies greater importance, whereas marginal elements are generally relegated to a subordinate role. This hierarchical arrangement of visual components allows for the effective communication of layered meanings, emphasizing the relative significance of each element within the overall composition.

3.3 Zhang Delu's Multimodal Synergy Theory

In 2009, Zhang Delu established a comprehensive analytical framework grounded in SFG, investigating how multiple communicative modes interact within multimodal contexts. Zhang emphasized that the primary focus of multimodal research lies in investigating the interconnections among various semiotic systems and how they collaboratively realize the intended communicative purpose. These diverse semiotic systems are designed to construct the message of the communicator.

Zhang Delu's classification of intermodal connections distinguishes between complementary and non-complementary interactions. The complementary type is further subdivided into reinforcing and non-reinforcing patterns. Within reinforcement,

one semiotic mode assumes the dominant role in conveying information, while others provide supplementary support without taking center stage. The non-reinforcement describes simultaneous semiotic systems of equal significance that collectively contribute to meaning-making. The reinforcement includes highlighting, primary and secondary, and extension. Non-reinforcement includes coordination, coalition, and intersection. Non-complementary interactions can be classified into three categories: inclusive, overlapping, and contextual.

3.4 A Proposed Framework for the Present Research

This study develops an integrated analytical model for the present research. The proposed analytical model for this research is structured as follows:

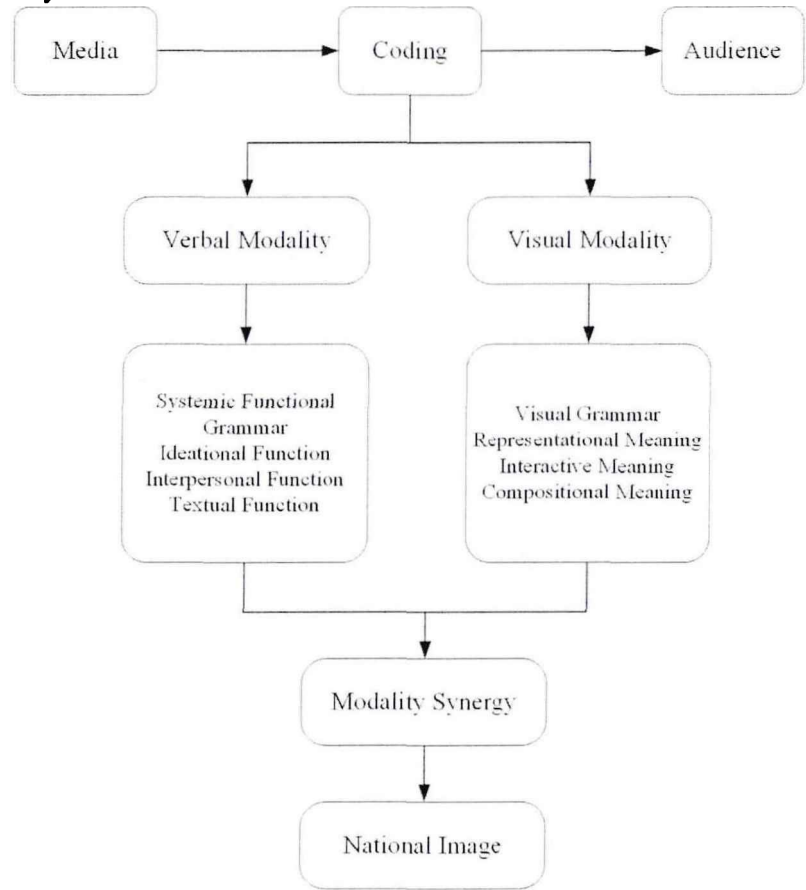


Figure 3.1 The analytical framework for the thesis

Given the nature of the selected promotional material, incorporating both verbal and visual semiotic resources, the investigation of verbal elements will employ Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar, whereas visual components will be analyzed through Kress and van Leeuwen's Visual Grammar framework. The integration of these distinct semiotic systems will be guided by Zhang Delu's theory of multimodal synergy.

This study takes the second season of the documentary *China on the Move* as its research subject, aiming to explore how verbal and visual modalities collaboratively construct the national image. Firstly, the examination of linguistic elements employs Halliday's SFG framework, specifically addressing the ideational, interpersonal, and textual functions. For visual semiotic resources, the investigation adopts Kress and van Leeuwen's grammar, encompassing representational, interactive, and compositional functions.

Secondly, this research extends its scope to examine the interaction between verbal and visual semiotic systems. Utilizing Zhang Delu's multimodal synergy framework, the investigation focuses on how verbal and visual elements collaborate to generate comprehensive meaning in multimodal texts.

Finally, the study delves into how verbal and visual modalities collaboratively construct the national image from a multimodal perspective, revealing how the documentary integrates multimodal resources to shape a comprehensive and multidimensional image of China.

Chapter Four Multimodal Discourse Analysis of *China on the Move (Season 2)*

In this chapter, the thesis employs a qualitative approach within the established theoretical framework to analyze meaning construction in the documentary through two semiotic modalities: verbal and visual modalities. Subsequently, an integrated examination investigates the interplay between these communicative resources. Quantitative analysis is carried out with the help of multimodal discourse analysis software ELAN 6.9 so that the statistics show the frequency of use of various symbolic resources.

4.1 The Analysis of Modalities in the Documentary

4.1.1 The Analysis of Verbal Modality

The verbal modality in this documentary, comprising subtitles and voice-over narration, plays a crucial role in meaning-making alongside visual elements. Given their significance in the promotional video, this section examines the verbal semiotic resources through Halliday's SFG. Transitivity functions as a semantic framework that categorizes human experiences, such as observations, perception, and actions, into different processes. At its core, this system reflects that human experience is fundamentally characterized by a continuous sequence of events or occurrences. This flow of events can be summarized as different processes: the process of happening, doing, sensing, saying, being, or having. The verbal modality of the video was collected and revised, and then the verbal modality was imported into the UAM Corpus Tool 6 for examining and annotating the clauses according to the transitivity system. The transitivity distribution of each process is shown in Table 4.1.

Table 4.1 Transitivity distribution of processes

Process type	Frequency	Percentage
Material process	281	61.09%
Relational process	127	27.61%
Mental process	32	6.96%
Existential process	10	2.17%
Verbal process	9	1.95%
Behavioral process	1	0.22%
Total	460	100%

As presented, material processes constitute the largest proportion, accounting for 61.09%. The high frequency of material processes underscores the documentary’s emphasis on concrete actions and events, centering on tangible practices in social welfare. This foregrounds China’s practical measures and progress in livelihood improvement, reflecting its proactive governance in addressing civil issues. Meanwhile, the objective narrative embedded in material processes aligns with the documentary’s adherence to authenticity and fact-based representation. Relational processes follow, making up 27.61% of the total. Relational processes, through delineating China’s societal realities, present evaluative information on its achievements. Mental processes account for 6.96%, and verbal processes contribute 1.95%. Behavioral processes are the least frequent, occurring only once and representing 1.47% of the total. The interplay between predominant material processes and relational processes establishes an action-outcome chain, thereby accentuating both governance capacity and policy effectiveness. In the next section, the different types of processes are further analyzed.

4.1.1.1 The Ideational Function

The function refers to the use of linguistic resources by individuals to articulate their worldly experiences and depict events. This function consists of two key components: transitivity and voice. Process types encompass six categories: material, mental, relational, behavioral, verbal, and existential processes. Material processes

represent actions or events. These processes are not confined to concrete or physical occurrences; they can also encompass abstract actions and events. Two participant roles in material clauses are the Actor and the Goal. In the documentary, the material process is mainly used to describe the concrete practice and great achievements of China's implementation of rural revitalization. The most commonly used verbs are "work", "start", "come", "develop", "live", "make," and so on. These material processes demonstrate both the real personal stories of China as well as its exploration and achievements in the field of people's livelihoods.

Example 1: China (Actor) was launching (Material Process) its targeted poverty alleviation strategy (Goal).

Example 2: We (Actor) started to explore (Material Process) a model for sustainable rural development (Goal) in 2020.

Example 3: Tang Wende (Actor) returned (Material Process) to his hometown, hoping to play his part.

The Actor is usually the main body that carries out the action, while the Goal is the participant that is impacted by the process. In the documentary, the Actors include the government, villagers, enterprises, social organizations, and other subjects, reflecting the model of poverty alleviation and rural revitalization through multi-party collaboration.

In Example 1, China is explicitly the performer of action represented by the Process "was launching". It is China that performs the action, and it is the targeted poverty alleviation strategy that undergoes the action. The process "was launching" highlights the transition from the planning to the implementation of policies at the national level. The first sentence introduces China's launch of the targeted poverty alleviation strategy, so national departments began to explore a model for sustainable rural development. The Actor "We" converts policy into practice-level pathways through the "explore" material process. In Example 3, the villager here is the participant in the action, demonstrating his initiative and motivation in rural development. By specifying the participants, the material process not only shows the implementers of the action but also highlights the importance of multi-party collaboration in rural

revitalization. Ultimately, through the joint efforts of the entire Party and all ethnic groups across the country, China achieved a comprehensive victory in its fight against poverty.

From the perspective of actor configuration, the hierarchical structure of the state “China”, collective institutions, and individual actors reflects China’s governance paradigm in livelihood development, which is characterized by coordinated state leadership and citizen participation. In terms of material processes, a top-down policy cycle is constructed from policy initiation to model exploration to individual implementation on the ground, codifying state directives into concrete, socially embedded outcomes.

Example 4: The villages’ revenue (Actor) increased (Material Process) by 40% from the previous year, and villagers’ incomes (Actor) continue to grow (Material Process).

In the first clause, the Actor here is the villages’ revenue, which undergoes the material process of “increase”. This highlights the economic growth experienced by the village, as a key participant in the action. This material process describes a concrete economic change—specifically, the rise in revenue. The Circumstance provides quantitative and temporal context, specifying the extent of the increase and the time frame. This enhances the factual precision and credibility of the statement. In the second clause, the Actor is the villagers’ incomes, which are depicted as undergoing a continuous process of growth. This foregrounds the improvement in individual livelihoods as a central focus. The use of the verb “grow” conveys a sense of sustained progress, aligning with the documentary’s theme of continuous development in people’s livelihoods.

The sentence employs two material processes to describe the increase in village revenue and the growth of villagers’ incomes. The use of material processes underscores the documentary’s focus on tangible, measurable improvements in the economic aspects of people’s livelihoods. Overall, the analysis demonstrates how the use of material processes in this sentence effectively communicates the documentary’s central message: the tangible and ongoing improvements in China’s social development,

particularly in the realm of people's livelihoods. This aligns with the narrative style of the documentary, which relies on factual data and concrete examples to illustrate progress.

Mental processes are concerned with our experience of our consciousness (Halliday, 2014). They describe psychological activities such as perception, emotion, cognition, or desire. They are clauses of sensing.

Example 5: At the same time, I (senser) have also seen (Mental Process) a big increase in the gap between the rich and especially the super-rich and the poor (Phenomenon).

In mental processes, a human participant is referred to as the Senser. This participant is characterized by consciousness, enabling him to perceive, feel, or think. The other key element in such clauses, the Phenomenon, occupies a contrasting role. While the Senser is the conscious entity experiencing the mental activity, the Phenomenon represents the object or concept being perceived. In Example 5, "I" is the senser, the human participant who sees, indicating that the Senser is endowed with consciousness. The group "have seen" is the central mental process. The mental process is the verb that describes the act of perception or feeling. The choice of a mental process highlights the subjective nature of the observation, emphasizing that the statement reflects the narrator's personal experience or viewpoint. The phenomenon is what is being perceived, thought about, or felt. In this sentence, the phenomenon is "a big increase in the gap between the rich and especially the super-rich and the poor". "A big increase" is the central noun phrase describing the magnitude of the change. This phenomenon reflects a critical social issue, aligning with the documentary's focus on people's livelihoods and social inequality. The host here notes the rapid growth of China's economy, which also demonstrates the complexity and uniqueness of China's social development. The sentence employs a mental process to convey the narrator's subjective observation of a significant social issue—the widening wealth gap, particularly between the super-rich and the poor. Critical narration is embedded in the positive narrative to expose the dialectical complexity of China's development model.

Relational processes function to characterize and define entities (Halliday, 2014). These processes demonstrate the logical connections between two elements, which Halliday categorized into two primary types: Attributive and Identifying processes. Attributive processes are featured with Carrier and Attribute, while identifying processes are concerned with Identified and Identifier.

Example 6: Baiyan village (Identified) became (Relational Process) what is referred to as a hollow village with extreme poverty (Identifier).

Example 7: The village (Carrier) is (Relational Process) now dotted with fancy guest houses (Attribute).

The two processes are relational. Example 6 exemplifies an identifying relational process, where the verb “became” establishes a relationship of identity between Baiyan village and its new classification as a “hollow village with extreme poverty.” Example 7 illustrates an attributive relational process, where the verb “is” assigns a descriptive attribute “dotted with fancy guest houses” to the Carrier “the village”, emphasizing its transformed state. In Example 6, Baiyan village is identified as a hollow village. In Example 7, there are an Attribute, “dotted with fancy guest houses,” and a Carrier, “the village”. In the identifying structure, something has an identity assigned to it. Something is to be identified as the Identified and something serves as identity, as the Identifier. In Example 6, the identifying relational process marks the village’s initial identity as a “hollow village with extreme poverty”, highlighting the severity of its impoverished condition. This constructs the starting point of the narrative, emphasizing the challenges faced in the poverty alleviation campaign. In contrast, Example 7 employs an attributive relational process to depict the village’s current state as “dotted with fancy guest houses,” symbolizing the tangible outcomes of developmental efforts. These two examples illustrate the great changes that have taken place in Baiyan village, a poor village in China. Baiyan village once became an extremely impoverished “hollow village.” Now, the village has started developing guesthouse projects, leading to a continuous increase in villagers’ incomes and a sense of happiness and satisfaction among the residents. This shift from an identifying to an attributive relational process reflects a symbolic transformation in the village’s identity, from a place of deprivation

to a place with economic vitality and modernization. The beautiful village guesthouse project in which Baiyan village is involved was even selected by the United Nations as a successful case of sustainable development.

The juxtaposition of Example 6 and Example 7 employs relational processes to construct a cohesive narrative of China's poverty alleviation policy. This narrative symbolizes a transformative breakthrough from poverty to prosperity, achieved through the redefinition of the village's identity. Specifically, developmental success is concretized through the representation of Guizhou's guesthouses, which serve as a tangible manifestation of progress.

In terms of verbal processes, verbal processes are clauses of saying. The verbal process is the process of transmitting and communicating information through speech, and it involves the Sayer and the content of the speech.

Example 8: The government (sayer) says (verbal process) that the next stage in local development is something called rural revitalization (verbiage).

The clause is structured around a verbal process, which represents processes of saying or communicating. The Sayer is the participant responsible for the verbal process. In this case, the government is the entity communicating the message. The choice of the government as the Sayer positions it as an authoritative source of information, reinforcing the legitimacy and importance of the message. The Verbiage is the content of what is said. It encapsulates the message being communicated by the Sayer. Here, the Verbiage introduces the concept of rural revitalization as the next phase of local development, framing it as a strategic and planned initiative. The Verbiage corresponds to what is said. The example is the quotation of the China government. It indicates that China's next phase will focus on rural revitalization as a key objective, which is a national strategy aimed at promoting comprehensive economic and social development in rural areas. In Example 8, the verbal process is used to project the government's authoritative voice, introducing the concept of rural revitalization as the next phase of local development. The embedded relational process within the verbiage further reinforces this by defining rural revitalization as a key attribute of the next developmental stage. This construction not only communicates a policy agenda but also

positions the government as the central actor in driving and narrating the process of rural transformation.

In terms of existential processes, existential processes represent that something exists or happens. In every existential process, there is only one participant and the existent.

Example 9: There are nearly 600 million farmers in China, accounting for more than 40% of China's population.

This type of progress can be realized grammatically in two main forms: through a copular verb or an empty “there” construction. Textually, the theme, “there,” serves as a marker of existence, preparing the addressee for something that is about to be introduced and something being presented as new information. This section introduces the basic national conditions of China, which include a large population base, with 600 million people living in rural areas, accounting for 40% of the total population.

4.1.1.2 The Interpersonal Function

In Halliday's opinion, the interpersonal function encompasses the ways language is used to establish and maintain social and personal relationships. This function involves the speaker's engagement in a communicative act. The interpersonal function is realized by mood and modality. Mood, which consists of the Subject and the Finite element, reflects the speaker's chosen role within a communicative context and the role assigned to the listener. It is categorized into three primary forms: declarative, interrogative, and imperative. Modality, on the other hand, indicates whether the speaker is articulating a judgment or offering a prediction. Modality further clarifies whether the speaker is expressing a subjective judgment or projecting a future possibility. Together, mood and modality provide a framework for understanding how language facilitates interaction and conveys the speaker's stance within a given discourse.

Example 10: Is (Finite element) it (Subject) possible to share the fruits of development so that everyone can benefit from what the government calls Common prosperity?

Example 11: A good reform direction (Subject) for the future is (Finite element) to gradually bridge the gap between urban and rural areas.

In both examples, the two clauses share the same verb form, ‘is’, to convey tense. According to the order of subject and finite element, Example 10 realizes a yes-no interrogative, and Example 11 realizes a declarative tone. In Example 11, the Chinese expert introduces the audience to the direction in which China will continue to strive for development in the future through a declarative tone, demonstrating China’s courage to face up to the problem and take it on and showing the interpersonal significance of China’s continued endeavors. Interrogative sentences are relatively scarce in the documentary, and the interrogative sentences carry a notably strong tone. These sentences are strategically designed to capture the audience’s attention and stimulate their curiosity. For instance, Example 10 aims to engage the audience by prompting them to reflect on and uncover the answers to the questions posed, thereby fostering a deeper level of interaction and involvement.

Modality construes a region of uncertainty, an assessment of the validity of what is being said. Modality represents the speaker’s judgment. The selection of the degree of modality in modal verbs to express discourse stance requires careful consideration of the semantic functions they convey, as modal verbs of different degrees (high, median, and low) serve distinct semantic purposes. The process of choosing among high, median, and low-value modal verbs is inherently linked to the selection of their discourse functions, reflecting the interplay between semantic intent and communicative purpose (Wei Benli, 2005).

Table 4.2 Distribution of modality value

Modality value	Modal verb	Frequency
Low	might, can	18
Median	will, would, should	7
High	must, have to	6

As we can see, the documentary mainly uses low-modal verbs, which are used to express the speakers’ attitude, judgment, or possibility of the proposition, so the modal

verbs' frequency and type of use can reflect the tone, position, and relationship with the audience of the verbal modality.

Low-modal verbs usually express a lower degree of certainty or compulsion, suggesting a possibility or suggestion rather than an absolute assertion. In the Episode 5 of the documentary, the frequent use of low-modal verbs may indicate that the documentary tries to present information in an open and negotiated way, rather than imposing certain views or conclusions, which helps to reduce the authority of the language and make the language more amiable and inclusive. This language strategy helps to establish an equal dialogue relationship with the audience and encourages the audience to think independently and form their own judgments. The high frequency of use of low-modal verbs may also reflect the documentary's recognition of the complexity of the problems, suggesting that there are no easy answers or unique solutions to these problems. The high frequency of using low-modal verbs may indicate that the documentary is more inclined to present information in an objective and neutral way.

The use of the high modal value carries strong subjective tendencies or ideological overtones. This language strategy helps to enhance the credibility and persuasiveness of the documentary. Below, some specific examples will be analyzed to illustrate.

Example 12: We must establish cooperatives that pool the resources of the whole village and unite the villagers.

Example 13: We sing and dance like this at festivals. This is what this village should be like. We feel happy and satisfied.

Example 14: With the change in people's job opportunities and income, they should also be given choices, including commercial insurance.

Example 15: So that we can build up a multi-level social security system.

According to the degree of modality, modal verbs have three kinds of modal values: high, median, and low value. Different modal values reflect the specific attitude of the speaker and realize different interpersonal meanings. The above example sentences sequentially realize high, median, and low modal values. Examples 13 and 14 reflect the median modal value. Example 11 summarizes a well-functioning rural

sustainable development model that China has developed through multiple explorations. The model includes four principles. These principles are all valuable experiences from China, and each one is very important, hence the use of “must” to emphasize the tone. The median modal value can bring people closer together and build good interpersonal relationships. In Example 13, the head of Baiyan village uses the median modal “should” to express his hope for a better life in the countryside, which is in the happy festivals, the villagers singing and dancing happily. The low-value modal verb “can” circumvents arbitrary conclusions, increases the negotiation space of the discourse, and makes the tone euphemistic and acceptable. Here, when the Chinese expert talks about the social security of the flexible workers, he chooses a low-value modal verb, which indicates that China is trying to build a multi-level social security system, achieving the interpersonal purpose of reassuring the flexible workers.

4.1.1.3 The Textual Function

At the semantic level, the function integrates linguistic elements into a unified text or helps ideas “hang together. The function is mainly illustrated by the thematic structures and cohesive devices. Theme, defined as the starting point of the clause, provides the context and orientation for the message. The speaker chooses the theme as his or her point of departure to guide the addressee in developing an interpretation of the message by making part of the message prominent as a theme. The remainder of the message in the clause is called the rheme. The textual function describes how individuals convey coherent meaning by structuring linguistic units into a united text. This section focuses on the thematic structure of the verbal modality to examine how clauses are arranged within the linguistic context. This is illustrated in Example 16 and Example 17:

Example 16: Guizhou (Theme) used to have the largest percentage of poor people in the country. (Rheme)

Example 17: How (Theme) should hollow villages develop? (Rheme)

Example 16 provides a straightforward example of the unmarked theme in textual function. When the topic of a sentence unit coincides with its grammatical subject, it is

termed the Theme. If the topic diverges from the grammatical subject, it is classified as a Rheme. Example 16 takes Guizhou as the Theme of the first clause and presents it as given information. It takes the theme-rheme structure of the text to show the thematic progression. It introduced the rural situation in Guizhou province. In Example 17, there is an adverbial phrase that marks the theme. Typically, unless there is a specific rationale, speakers prefer the default topic as the initial focus of discourse. However, speakers may opt for an emphatic topic to underscore a particular element. In this case, the topic ‘how’ is prominently emphasized to capture the audience’s focus on the approach to hollow village development.

4.1.2 The Analysis of Visual Modality

4.1.2.1 Representational Meaning

This section aims to examine visual modality in the framework of Kress and van Leeuwen’s VG. Representational meaning is further divided into two distinct processes: the narrative process and the conceptual process. Narrative patterns portray dynamic actions, transformative processes, and temporary spatial arrangements, whereas conceptual patterns depict participants based on their class, structure, or meaning, capturing their enduring and unchanging nature. The defining feature of narrative visual representations is the presence of a vector, which is always found in narrative structures but absent in conceptual ones. (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2006). By analyzing these processes, the study seeks to uncover how visual elements convey meaning, interact with the audience, and organize compositional structures, thereby providing a comprehensive understanding of visual communication within the proposed framework.

Based on the distinct features of images, various types of processes are distinguished according to the types of vectors and the kind of participants engaged. For precise analysis, Episode 5 of the documentary was uploaded into ELAN 6.9. Once the process types were labeled, a table was created to display the distribution of temporal lengths for each process in the video. Table 4.3 illustrates the percentage distribution of various processes.

Table 4.3 The proportion of different processes

Type of process	Time Duration (s)	Percentage (%)
Action process	755.80s	52.49%
Reactional process	286.96s	19.92%
Speech and mental process	370.24s	25.71%
Classificational process	169.87s	11.79%
Analytical process	166.28s	11.54%
Symbolic process	59.75s	4.14%

The data presented in the table reveals a significant predominance of narrative processes over conceptual processes within the documentary. Specifically, the action processes, reactional processes, and speech and mental processes collectively constitute a substantial portion of the narrative framework. It is noteworthy that individual shots may simultaneously exhibit multiple processes; thus, the percentages reflect the proportion of each process relative to the entire video's duration. Consequently, the cumulative percentage of these processes exceeds 100%, highlighting the layered complexity of narrative construction within the documentary. The notably high proportion of action processes underscores the documentary's emphasis on showcasing China's practical actions and tangible achievements in enhancing people's livelihoods through dynamic visual storytelling. These action processes transform abstract development concepts into concrete visual narratives through visual symbols (such as character movements, scene changes, etc.), enhancing the audience's understanding and resonance with the theme. Additionally, the documentary skillfully employs the reactional processes by interviewing domestic and international scholars, experts, and local residents, capturing their gazes, expressions, and body language to convey diverse perspectives and viewpoints. This multi-layered narrative strategy not only strengthens the visual impact but also constructs a comprehensive and in-depth framework of understanding for the audience through multimodal interactions (such as the combination of language, expressions, and actions). Narrative structures are inherently dynamic, characterized by the presence of

at least one vector that directs the viewer’s attention and facilitates the progression of the narrative. All of these processes will be explained and exemplified in the subsequent sections of this analysis. This detailed exploration enhances the understanding of how narrative structures function and contributes to the overall meaning-making process in multimedia contexts.

“In action structures, the Actor is the participant from which the vector emanates” (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2021: 58). In images, they are often also the most salient participants. There are two types: transactional and non-transactional processes. “When images or diagrams representing action processes have a single participant, this participant is usually an Actor. The resulting structure we call non-transactional” (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2021: 59).

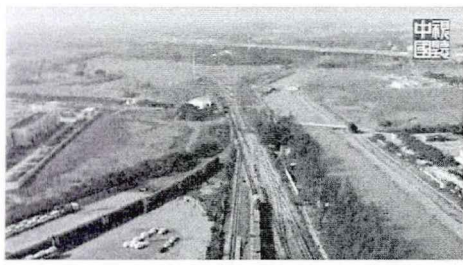
Table 4.4 A brief visual analysis of example 18

Example 18		
Time range	00:22-00:24	
Visual process	Non-transactional action process	
Participant	Actor: Cars	
Vector	The direction of the cars	
Circumstance	Setting: Roads, buildings	

The shot vividly captures the bustling scenes of urban traffic, a recurring image in the documentary. In terms of the representational function, the Actors are the cars, while the vectors are formed by the driving directions of these vehicles and the layout of the roads. The movement of cars does not directly impact a specific target, rendering these shots examples of non-transactional action processes. This shot highlights the city’s vitality and rapid progress, emphasizing its energetic atmosphere and ongoing transformation. The constant flow characterizes a thriving metropolis. By repeatedly

showcasing the busy traffic, the documentary emphasizes the city’s economic vitality and infrastructural advancements, painting a picture of a modern, fast-paced urban environment. This image not only highlights the city’s prosperity but also conveys a sense of progress and momentum.

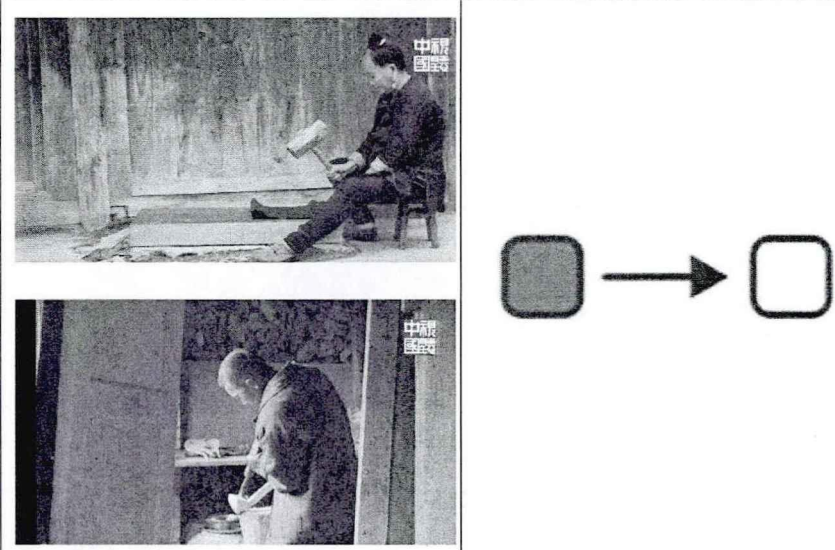
Table 4.5 A brief visual analysis of example 19

Example 19		
Time range	00:59-01:01	
Visual process	Non-transactional action process	
Participant	Actor: The trains	
Vector	The direction and route of the train	
Circumstance	Railway tracks	

The railway tracks and routines running across the image can realize the vectors. The trains driving on them are Actors in the process of driving. Since no goal is present in the image, it is categorized as a non-transactional action process. This vivid shot captures the thriving scene of modern railway transportation in China. They are not merely physically departing into the distance. They embody the prosperity of China’s railways and its robust economy, transcending mere geographical movement. From the audience’s perspective, as the trains advance, what is experienced transcends spatial displacement—it bears witness to the nation’s rapid development and embodies the people’s fervent aspirations for an even more prosperous and harmonious life. Far more than symbols of conveyance, these trains stand as epitomes of progress and the achievements of national construction. They convey a profound metaphor: Both individuals and the nation as a whole are perpetually advancing towards a brighter and more magnificent future. This depiction serves as a testament to relentless progress, encapsulating not just the physical journey of trains but also the aspirational journey of

a nation hurtling forward, embracing a future filled with promise and prosperity. Through this shot, the audience can intuitively grasp the rapid economic growth of China, and technological innovation and even the rapid development of China.

Table 4.6 A brief visual analysis of example 20

Example 20	
Time range	01:43-01:47
Visual process	Unidirectional transactional action process
Participant	Actor: Chinese people
Vector	Participants' hand movement
Circumstance	Setting

From the viewpoint of visual grammar, the images demonstrate the unidirectional transactional action process. The actors in these scenes are the arms and hands of the people, while the goals are the tasks they are diligently performing. The vectors are their arm and hand movements. In these scenes, the positive and down-to-earth spirit of the Chinese people is deeply revealed. Everyone demonstrates through their actions that “labor is the most glorious.” In rural homes, one can see people diligently feeding their poultry and livestock. At the same time, skilled craftsmen are fully engrossed in carving wood, and women are earnestly completing their work. On this vibrant land, men and women work side by side. These scenes vividly attest to the enduring essence of the Chinese people: their resilience in the face of hardship, their industriousness, and

their wisdom. Through these compelling images, a vivid and inspiring picture emerges of hundreds of millions of Chinese people striving tirelessly, with unwavering determination and hard work, for a brighter and more prosperous future. This portrayal not only highlights the collective spirit of the nation but also underscores the connection between labor and the pursuit of progress, painting a powerful narrative of hope, perseverance, and unity.

Table 4.7 A brief visual analysis of example 21

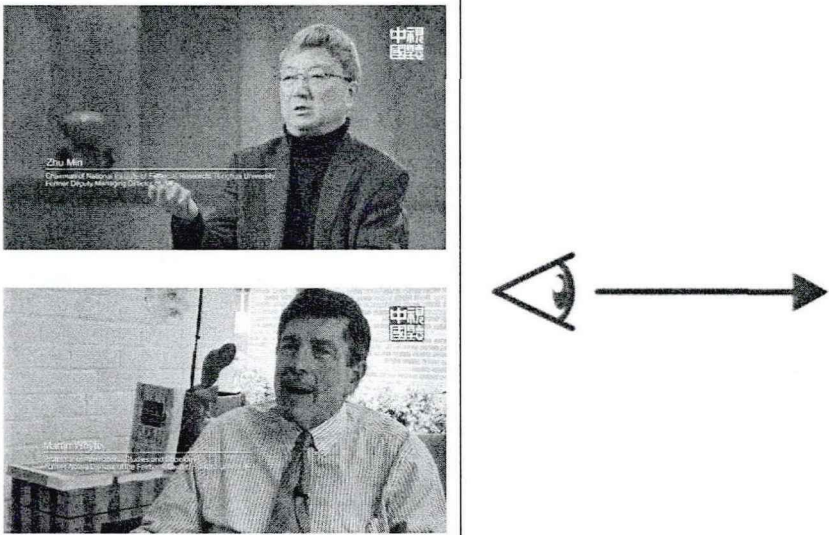
Example 21	
Time range	04:40-04:43
Visual process	Unidirectional transactional action process
Participant	Actor: The Miao villager
Vector	Participants' hand movement
Circumstance	Setting

The shot belongs to the unidirectional transactional action process in terms of narrative representation, which represents the behavior of individual participants. From the perspective of visual grammar, any symbolic pattern must be able to establish some kind of relationship, connect the designer and the audience, and convey some kind of information. The actors in the images do not look directly at the camera, creating a certain lack of contact. However, this sense of distance helps establish a kind of imaginary relationship, allowing the audience to closely examine the traditional dress and makeup of the Miao people as if they were observing a specimen in a display case. This allows people to have the most direct and basic visual cognition of the Miao people in China, including their clothing, makeup, and headwear. The picture shows the unique national cultural traditions of ethnic minorities in Guizhou. Miao Embroidery, with its intricate patterns, highlights the mysterious cultural significance in their designs. These

visual cultural symbols are full of mystery and Oriental charm, and through the interactive meaning of images, they enhance the national cultural identity of the audience and establish their national self-confidence. This also inspires the international audience to yearn for the mysterious culture.

“When the vector is formed by an eyeline, by the direction of the glance of one or more of the participants, the structure is reactional. And we will speak not of Actors but of Reacters, and not of goals but of phenomena” (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2021: 62). The Reacter, must be human or a figure with observable eyes that can be depicted as directing their gaze and exhibiting expressive features. This phenomenon may be created by another figure, the one being gazed at by the reacting figure.

Table 4.8 A brief visual analysis of example 22

Example 22	
Time range	23:02-23:06 15:08-15:48
Visual process	No-transactional reaction process
Participant	Interviewees
Vector	Eyeline
Circumstance	Setting

In these scenes, the participants are interviewed, articulating their thoughts and viewpoints. They gaze at someone or something that the audience can’t see. From a visual grammar perspective, these frames are classified as offer images. The

interviewees act as Reacters, with their gaze lines functioning as the vectors. As there is no observable element or phenomenon within the images, these are identified as non-transactive reactional structures. The audience can infer that the phenomenon is the interviewer, who remains unseen but is implicitly present beyond the frame.

The documentary skillfully integrates the perspectives of numerous Chinese and foreign experts, encompassing both the lived experiences and reflective insights of domestic individuals, as well as the analytical viewpoints of international specialists. This collection of voices from diverse national backgrounds not only provides firsthand accounts from those within China but also incorporates the unique perspectives of foreign experts. By presenting a diverse range of viewpoints, the documentary achieves a more authentic, nuanced, and comprehensive portrayal of China, significantly enhancing the narrative’s credibility and persuasiveness.

Table 4.9 A brief visual analysis of example 23

Example 23		
Time range	08:45-08:50	
Visual process	Bidirectional Reaction process	
Participant	The host and the resident in the Baiyan village	
Vector	Eyeline	
Circumstance	Setting	

From the viewpoint of visual grammar, the image illustrates the reactional structure. In the shot, the host and the resident engage in direct contact while conversing, thereby serving simultaneously as both Reacters and phenomena. The vector is their gazes, with the primary circumstance element being the setting in which the interaction takes place. The resident in Baiyan village is sharing her experiences related to poverty alleviation, while the host and the resident discuss the broader theme of rural

revitalization in China. This dialogue highlights the remarkable achievements China has made in recent years and also states the downsides of this model. The interview scene depicted in the images captures serious and focused conversations between foreign hosts and Chinese residents. Both parties exhibited full attentiveness and engagement during the interview, fostering a genuine and meaningful exchange. The host listens intently to the interviewee, demonstrating a deep level of interest and respect, while the Chinese interviewee maintains eye contact with the host, sharing her opinions and ideas with honesty and openness. These authentic interviews with ordinary Chinese residents not only enhance the credibility and emotional impact of the documentary but also effectively communicate China’s stories to a global audience. By presenting a truthful and relatable portrayal of China, the documentary bridges cultural divides and offers a nuanced understanding of the nation’s experiences.

Table 4.10 A brief visual analysis of example 24

Example 24	
Time range	06:56-07:04
Visual process	Speech and mental process
Participant	People
Vector	Facial expression
Circumstance	Setting

The image captures a group of individuals standing closely together, their faces illuminated by shared laughter. In terms of the narrative structure, this shot realizes a speech and mental process. Their radiant facial expressions and joyful demeanor convey a profound sense of inner happiness, allowing the audience to intuitively feel their genuine delight and contentment. This moment captures more than just individual joy; it reflects the community’s great happiness because of the implementation of rural

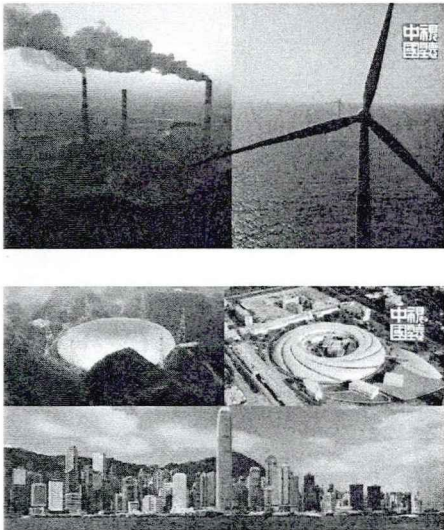
revitalization. Baiyan village in Guizhou Province was once a relatively underdeveloped and impoverished community. However, through the implementation of China's national rural revitalization, the village has successfully harnessed its unique natural landscapes and rich cultural resources to drive comprehensive development. Today, Baiyan village stands as a testament to the power of strategic planning and community effort, attracting visitors with its picturesque scenery and vibrant cultural atmosphere. The village's transformation has not only increased the income of local farmers but has also significantly enhanced the quality of life and the spiritual well-being of its residents.

During festivals and celebrations, the villagers come together to sing, dance, and rejoice, marking their bountiful harvests and the prosperity of their community. These gatherings are not merely celebrations of material success but also expressions of a flourishing and harmonious way of life. Baiyan village has emerged as a vivid and shining example of China's rural cultural revitalization, demonstrating how traditional values and modern development can coexist and thrive. Its success story offers valuable practical experience and inspiration for the construction of beautiful countryside not only within China but also across the globe. Through its journey, Baiyan village embodies the spirit of resilience, innovation, and unity, serving as a model for sustainable rural development worldwide.

In conclusion, through the narrative processes, this documentary dynamically presents the developmental landscape of China's modernization process and the everyday life of its people through the use of action processes. Simultaneously, by employing the reactional processes, it systematically integrates multidimensional perspectives from both domestic and international experts as well as local residents, effectively constructing the authenticity and credibility of the narrative discourse. This dual application of narrative processes not only strengthens the representational function of the visual text but also achieves a multidimensional presentation and international dissemination of China's story at the level of interactive meaning.

The conceptual representations distinguished three kinds of conceptual structure: classification, analytical and symbolic structures.

Table 4.11 A brief visual analysis of example 25

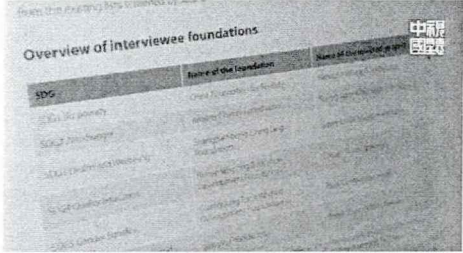
Example 25	
Time range	00:34-00:35, 00:37-00:39
Visual process	Classificational process
Participant	China's super-projects
Vector	No vector

These shots are examples of the classificational process as they collectively illustrate a cohesive theme despite not being captured within the same frame. While the images are distinct, their underlying similarities are evident in several key aspects. All the projects depicted belong to the same overarching category: they are integral components of China's super engineering initiatives, which reflect the nation's commitment to high-quality industrial development and the rapid advancement of its innovation capabilities. These images showcase a series of majestic super-projects in China, including massive industrial facilities, wind power bases, and major innovation infrastructure such as the "Five-hundred-meter Aperture Spherical Telescope" (FAST) in Guizhou and the "Shanghai Synchrotron Radiation Facility" in Shanghai. These facilities not only significantly advance the development of related fields but also serve as powerful assets for Chinese scientists in international competition. Additionally, the construction of these projects will promote the development of numerous high-tech sectors, substantially enhancing China's original innovation capabilities. These images

collectively highlight China’s transformative journey toward becoming a global leader in science, technology, and industrial development. They not only celebrate the nation’s engineering marvels but also underscore the broader implications of these projects for economic growth, scientific discovery, and international collaboration. Through these super-projects, China demonstrates its unwavering commitment to innovation-driven development and its vision for a future shaped by technological excellence.

Within the analytical process, the structure exhibits a composition of components and entirety. Two types of participants are involved in the process: the Carrier, representing the entirety, and possessive features, representing the components.

Table 4.12 A brief visual analysis of example 26

Example 26	
Time range	07:28-07:37
Visual process	Analytical process
Participant	Carrier: The table Possessive attribute: other projects in this table

The shot presents a table in which the Baiyan village guest house project was selected by the United Nations as a successful model of sustainable development. In terms of the conceptual structure, this image realizes an analytical process, as it emphasizes the relationship between individual components and the broader whole. The table itself serves as an analytical framework, presenting a comprehensive overview of multiple projects, with the Baiyan village guest house project standing out as one notable example among them. The inclusion of the Baiyan village project in this table underscores its significance as a benchmark for sustainable development. Its recognition by the United Nations not only reflects the UN’s high regard for the project’s rapid progress and transformative impact but also serves as a testament to China’s remarkable achievements in poverty alleviation. By showcasing the successful

integration of local resources, cultural heritage, and innovative development strategies, the Baiyan village project provides a replicable model for other nations grappling with similar challenges. This recognition offers valuable insights and experience for global poverty reduction efforts. It reinforces the idea that China’s achievements in poverty alleviation and sustainable development are not isolated phenomena but part of a global movement toward inclusive and equitable progress.

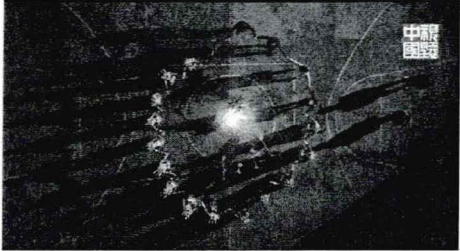
Table 4.13 A brief visual analysis of example 27

Example 27	
Time range	07:15-07:17
Visual process	Analytical process
Participant	Carrier: the Miao villagers Possessive attribute: Lushengs

The shot belongs to the analytical structure. In the analytical structure, the participants have the roles of carrier and attribute. This image is about the way participants fit together to make up a larger whole. The carrier represents the whole and a number of other participants, and the possessive attributes represent the parts. Therefore, Miao villagers function as carriers, and the Lushengs function as possessive attributes, as the parts that make up the whole. The image depicts Miao villagers from Baiyan Village, Guizhou Province, playing the Lusheng, a traditional musical instrument. The villagers perform this activity primarily during festive occasions, accompanied by elegant dance movements, making it one of the most well-preserved cultural practices in Baiyan Village. The performing Miao villagers can be regarded as a whole, with the instrument in their hands, the Lusheng being the possessive attribute. The photograph not only encapsulates the distinctive ethnic culture and intangible cultural heritage of the Miao, one of China’s ethnic minorities but also vividly illustrates the positive outcomes of the nation’s targeted poverty alleviation strategy.

This image serves as a testament to the harmonious integration of cultural preservation and economic development within the context of contemporary China.

Table 4.14 A brief visual analysis of example 28

Example 28	
Time range	07:03-07:23
Visual process	Symbolic process
Participant	Carrier: The circles Symbolic attribute: unity and happiness

In terms of the conceptual structure, the image realizes the symbolic process. The circles are carriers, symbolizing the unity of the Chinese people. The villagers in Guizhou and the hosts hold hands, forming circle after circle, singing and dancing to traditional folk songs. This scene vividly portrays the happy and prosperous life of the people under the leadership of the Communist Party of China and profoundly illustrates the rich essence of ethnic unity and the closeness of one united family. The circles of villagers not only showcase the interconnectedness and inclusiveness of the Chinese people but also reflect their open attitude.

4.1.2.2 Interactive Meaning

“Visual mode also has resources for constituting and maintaining another kind of interaction: the interaction between the producers and the viewers” (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2021: 113). The analysis of interactive meaning is carried out from four perspectives: contact, social distance, attitude, and modality. Consequently, these images are primarily examined based on these four dimensions. The proportion of the offer and demand act is shown below.

Table 4.15 The proportion of offer and demand images

Contact	Time Duration (s)	Percentage (%)
Offer act	1296.8s	90.59%
Demand act	134.6s	9.41%

In the documentary, the fact that the offer act accounts for 90.59% indicates a significant emphasis on concrete action or initiatives being taken. This high percentage suggests that the documentary focuses heavily on actions and strategies implemented to drive progress or address challenges rather than merely discussing problems or making observations. It reflects a narrative centered on active engagement and forwards momentum in China’s development.

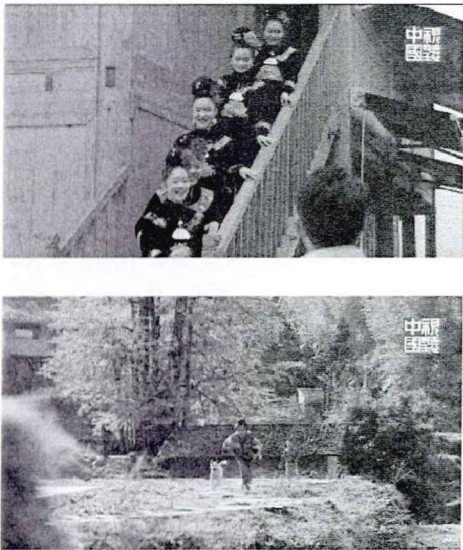
Table 4.16 A brief visual analysis of example 29

Example 29	
Time range	06:52-07:03, 08:22-08:25
Contact act	Offer act
Participant	The men
Vector	The men’s eyelines

The two images presented above all belong to the Offer Act. These shots represent different individuals. The offer act can be inferred from the participants’ eyelines and

gestures depicted in the images. As shown, the first man is holding his camera to record the beautiful scene of Guizhou, while the second man is engrossed in flipping through a book's pages; neither of them makes direct eye contact with the audience. In terms of gesture, all three men are facing sideways towards both the screen and the audience, focusing their attention on their respective activities. According to behavioral analysis, they all hold objects in their hands, which form a vector as if showcasing their work to the audience. Therefore, it can be observed that these images objectively present relevant information to the audience.

Table 4.17 A brief visual analysis of example 30

Example 30	
Time range	04:44-04:46, 09:00-09:02
Contact act	Demand act
Participant	The young girls and the children
Vector	People's eyelines

These shots are a powerful representation of demand acts as they establish direct contact between the depicted figures and the audience. The images capture the radiant smiles of Chinese people, particularly the children and beautiful girls, who are closely grouped, joyfully gazing at the viewer. Their smiles and piercing gazes create an intense visual engagement, inviting the audience into an imagined connection with them. This gaze functions as a bridge, linking the figures to the viewer and compelling them to

emotionally engage with the scene. The composition emphasizes unity and joy, with the figures' proximity suggesting a shared sense of happiness and community. Each smile radiates infectious enthusiasm, vividly conveying a life filled with contentment and fulfillment. Through this visual narrative, the shots not only depict a happy life in the village but also actively demand the audience's participation, positioning them as part of this joyful collective. The bright, inviting expressions and the direct eye contact establish a relationship of social affinity, fostering a sense of connection and shared emotion. These images go beyond mere representation; they actively construct a shared experience of happiness, making the audience feel as though they are part of the village's vibrant and harmonious life.

In terms of the frame size, frame sizes include close-up, medium, and long shots. Visual creators need to decide whether to portray the subjects nearer to or more distant from the audience. The selection of proximity indicates varying connections between the portrayed figures and the observers. For instance, the close-up shot focuses on the upper body of the subject, while the medium shot captures the figure approximately at knee level. In the long shot, the human figure takes up approximately half the vertical space of the frame. The following table illustrates the different frame sizes:

Table 4.18 The proportion of different frame sizes

Frame size	Time duration (s)	Percentage (%)
Close-up shot	78.30s	5.48%
Medium shot	569.95s	39.90%
Long shot	780.21s	54.62%

Frame size builds the psychological relationship between the audience and the person in the image by simulating the physical distance between people. Close-ups are employed sparingly in the documentary. It serves to enhance emotional resonance and highlight key details. Medium shots typically display the upper body of a character along with the surrounding environment, so this shot captures both facial expressions and body language while providing sufficient background information to contextualize the character's relationship with their surroundings. Medium shots enable the audience

to perceive the participants' emotions while understanding the broader scene. Long shots, which often depict the entire body of a character within their environment, emphasize the relationship between the subject and the setting, offering a wider perspective. The long shot is frequently used to underscore the significance of the environment or present a macroscopic view, thereby highlighting the scale of issues or their profound implications. The proportion of long shots and medium shots reached 94.52%, which also reflects that the documentary pays more attention to the presentation of themes and backgrounds in narration rather than focusing on individual details. This choice of shots reflects the profound theme of the documentary, improving people's livelihood. The topic requires the audience to understand the broader background and context. This choice of shots may reflect the narrative style, which focuses more on objectivity and information delivery than emotional agitation.

Table 4.19 A brief visual analysis of example 31

Example 31	
Time range	08:56-08:58, 04:41-04:43
Distance	Long shot and close shot

The two images respectively show a woman and a girl at different social distances. In the first image, she is depicted in the long shot. The human figure occupies about far from half the height of the frame. She is shown impersonally, as strangers with whom we do not need to become acquainted, as trees in a landscape. Indeed, she is so small

that we can hardly notice her or distinguish her facial features. Thus, the audience can't tell her emotions and wouldn't be affected. The second shot is depicted in a personal way, belonging to the close shot. In the image, we can only see the upper part of the girl's head and shoulders. The subject is centered and occupies half of the frame. If this were in reality, we would be near enough to reach out and touch her strands.

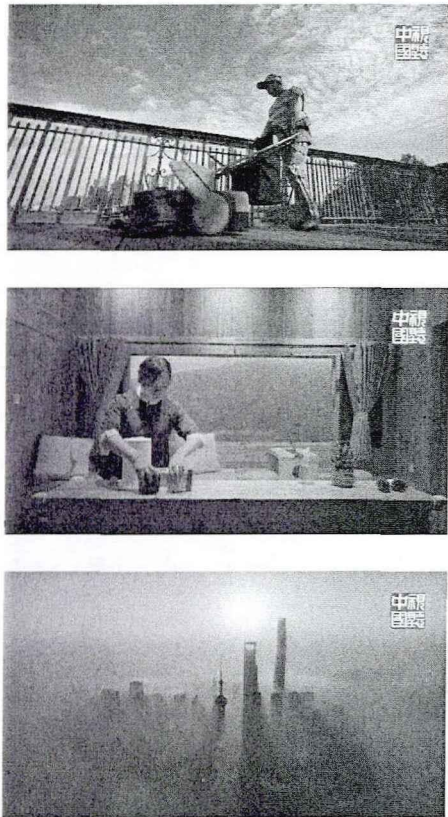
Table 4.20 A brief visual analysis of example 32

Example 32			
			
			
	Time range	02:28-02:30,	05:23-05:25 05:06-05:07
Perspective	Oblique angle; Frontal angle		
Participant	The women, the men and students		

The first two shots are taken from an oblique angle since the subjects are not directed toward the lens but are captured in profile or from behind. The producer didn't situate himself in front of the people he lined up. This viewpoint results in a lack of immediate engagement between the individuals and the audience. In the first two shots,

two elderly women are bent over in the fields, fully engrossed in harvesting crops, unaware of their surroundings, let alone the presence of the camera. The young man in the second shot is similarly entirely focused on his work as if everything around him doesn't exist. This oblique angle implies that the producer is not in the part of our world and not engaging with. In contrast, the last photo is radically different: it is taken from the front, and the people in the photo are aware of the camera's presence, all smiling and looking directly at the lens. The interaction between the participants and the audience's gazes creates a sense of engagement. This eye contact especially enhances the feeling of participation, making the audience feel as if they are right there, taking the photo, and genuinely experiencing the smiles and joy radiating from the group.

Table 4.21 A brief visual analysis of example 33

Example 33	
Time range	06:48-6:49, 06:45-06:46 04:10-04:11
Perspective	Low angle; Eye-level angle; High angle

In terms of the VG, it can be observed that the three frames are captured from the low angle, eye-level angle, and high angle, respectively. The relation between the interactive participant and the represented participant is seen from the point of view of power. Regarding the initial shot, it is captured from a low view. When the audience sees the sanitation worker, they are no longer looking down at him but instead are looking up. Due to the angle, the audiences are prompted to connect with the depicted figures in a specific manner. They are made to look up to them. This angle not only highlights the pride and honor the workers take in their jobs but also reflects the deep respect our society has for labor. It emphasizes that work is truly noble and deserving of admiration.

The second image is captured from an eye-level perspective, symbolizing equality between the participant and the viewers, and there is no power difference suggested. This framing underscores the principle of equality, emphasizing that women are equally capable and deserving of respect in their professional roles as men. Such a depiction not only highlights gender equity but also conveys a profound sense of dignity and acknowledgment for their contributions. The final image adopts the high angle viewpoint, offering a panoramic vista of the city. The angle enables the audience to have power over the represented participant, “the city”. This perspective allows the audience to comprehend the urban landscape in its entirety, creating a holistic and immersive understanding of the city’s scale and complexity. The composition fosters a sense of interconnectedness, inviting viewers to appreciate the collective identity of the urban environment.

These images reflect distinct yet complementary narratives: the first celebrates individual respect for the represented participant, worker, while the second emphasizes equality in the nation. The third image adopts the high angle to present the comprehensive scenery of the city. Both perspectives demonstrate a thoughtful approach to visual storytelling, balancing personal and communal dimensions to convey a comprehensive message. providing a broad view of the city. From this perspective, the entire city is encompassed, presenting the audience with an integrated and comprehensive impression of the city.

Table 4.22 A brief visual analysis of example 34

Example 34	
Time range	21:51-21:53 13:12-13:18
Modality	High modality

The first image vividly showcases the promotional activities for the 100th anniversary of the Communist Party of China. The steps are covered with a luxurious red carpet, symbolizing celebration and grandeur, while the prominent red slogans, rendered in bold and vibrant design, convey a sense of authority. The use of saturated red tones enhances the image’s realism, aligning it with a high-modality representation that reflects the significance and solemnity of the event. The second image depicts a scene of sanitation workers changing into their work clothes in the morning. The bright blue uniforms of the workers stand out against the backdrop of the office, which is adorned with vivid red flags of the CPC and red slogans. This combination of colors creates a striking visual impact, balancing the high modality of the red elements with the realistic depiction of the workers’ daily routine. The image captures a moment of ordinary life while embedding it within a broader ideological context, using color and composition to reinforce the connection between individual labor and collective identity. Both images employ high modality through their use of color and contrast, but they differ in their focus—one emphasizing grand ceremonial symbolism and the other highlighting the integration of ideology into everyday practices.

4.1.2.3 Compositional Meaning

The compositional structure aims to explore how the representational and interactive components are connected to one another and how they are unified within a coherent entirety. This meaning is realized through three interrelated systems: information value, salience, and framing.

Table 4.23 A brief visual analysis of example 35

Example 35	
Time range	07:47-07:50
Center	The tower
Margin	The buildings

The image captures a striking ancient tower prominently positioned at the center, surrounded by residential structures, which underscores its visual and cultural significance. Known as the Drum Tower, this architectural marvel is not merely a physical landmark but also the heart of the village’s communal life. Traditionally, the construction of Dong villages revolves around the Drum Tower, reflecting its central role in the community. It serves as a multifunctional space where villagers gather to discuss important matters, rest, and engage in cultural activities, embodying the social and spiritual essence of the Dong people.

Situated in a well-known tourist destination in Guizhou, the Drum Tower stands as a typical symbol of Dong culture, attracting visitors with its historical and architectural grandeur. Its towering presence and intricate craftsmanship not only highlight the artistic achievements of the Dong ethnic group but also serve as a testament to their enduring cultural heritage. As such, the Drum Tower transcends its physical form, becoming a living representation of tradition, unity, and identity in the modern world.

Table 4.24 A brief visual analysis of example 36

Example 36	
Time range	03:30-03:35, 20:00-20:11
Left	The man
Right	The guesthouse; the interviewee

In the first image, a woman is guiding the host to visit the Guesthouse where he will be staying. As the host pushes the door open, a sense of anticipation fills the scene, with the homestay prominently positioned on the right side of the frame. This arrangement establishes a clear visual dynamic: the host on the left represents familiar information, while the Guesthouse on the right introduces new content to the audience. The second image follows a similar left-right structure, with the host conducting an interview with a woman. The host, positioned on the left, serves as the anchor for the viewer's perspective, while the interviewee on the right provides fresh information. This compositional pattern ensures a logical flow, allowing the audience to process the narrative.

Both images strategically employ a left-right layout to convey information effectively. The left side consistently presents known elements—the host in both frames—while the right side introduces new material, such as the Guesthouse and the interviewee. This deliberate structure not only guides the viewer's attention but also enhances comprehension by organizing information in a visually intuitive manner.

Through this approach, the images communicate their message with clarity and purpose, making the narrative both engaging and accessible.

The second key compositional principle is framing. The more pronounced the boundary of an element, the more it is isolated from its surrounding context and depicted as a distinct entity. The lack of framing emphasizes collective identity, highlighting the separation.

Table 4.25 A brief visual analysis of example 37

Example 37	
Time range	17:13-17:16
Frameline	The table

Whether in an image or a layout, disconnection can be realized in different ways, such as frame lines or the strategic use of white space between elements. Such different ways of framing have different meaning potentials. For instance, frame lines create a sense of segregation, as seen in the image where the table serves as a boundary, both literally and figuratively, separating the parents from their child and symbolizing the emotional distance between them. However, such separation can be bridged. In the image, neither the parents nor the child remains confined to their respective spaces. Instead, the children's and the mother's arms extend forward, overlapping at the center of the table and even encroaching into each other's positions. This physical interaction conveys a harmonious familial relationship, subtly overcoming the initial sense of division.

This image also reflects broader societal trends in China, where the rise of online streamers has become a cultural phenomenon. Thanks to China's rapid economic and technological development, individuals now have greater career flexibility, allowing them to pursue occupations that align with their personal circumstances. This newfound

freedom grants them more time to nurture familial bonds, as depicted in the image. Thus, the visual narrative not only captures a moment of familial connection but also mirrors the evolving lifestyles and opportunities in contemporary Chinese society.

Salience can establish a ranking of significance among components, designating some as more significant and deserving of focus compared to others. Viewers of spatial arrangements instinctively assess the visual impact of different components, with more substantial impact correlating to higher prominence.

Table 4.26 A brief visual analysis of example 38

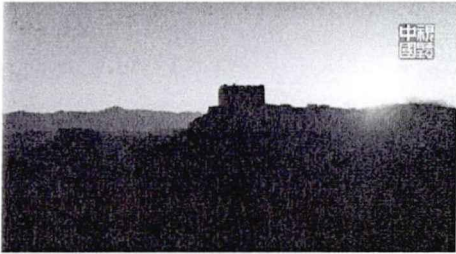
Example 38	
Time range	06:18-06:19, 06:23-06:24
Emphasized element	Glutinous rice cake

These two images together show the activity of the ethnic people in Guizhou gathering to make glutinous rice cakes. These two images collectively depict the traditional activity of ethnic communities in Guizhou, gathering to make glutinous rice cakes. From the salience perspective, key elements are highlighted through their size and positioning to capture the audience’s attention. In one of the shots, the glutinous rice cake is magnified and placed centrally, becoming the focal point, while the surrounding elements are intentionally blurred. This visual emphasis renders the rice cake more prominent than the background objects, drawing the audience’s gaze to its cultural significance.

This activity is deeply rooted in the customs of ethnic groups in Guizhou, particularly during festivals and important celebrations. The preparation of glutinous rice cakes is not merely a culinary tradition but also a symbolic act of unity and cooperation. Villagers work together closely, pounding the rice cake, a process that reflects their collective aspirations for a prosperous and harmonious life. Through this shared endeavor, they strengthen community bonds and celebrate their cultural heritage, showcasing the enduring richness of their traditions in the face of modernity.

In summary, when analyzing documentaries or other visual materials, the selected images are typically the most representative examples of the elements in the shot. Visual representation indeed possesses an extremely high level of complexity, which is mainly reflected in two aspects: first, a single image may simultaneously encompass multiple processes. Images can convey meaning through narrative processes and conceptual processes. Narrative processes typically involve actions, events, and changes, while conceptual processes more often depict classification, analysis, or symbolic meaning. In a single image, these processes may coexist and intertwine. For instance, a photograph might depict an action while also conveying an abstract concept through its symbols or composition. Second, an image does not merely achieve representational meaning but also carries interactive meaning and compositional meaning. Interactive meaning concerns the relationship between the image and the audience, such as influencing the audience's emotions or attitudes through gaze, distance, perspective, and other means. Compositional meaning, on the other hand, focuses on how visual elements like layout, color, contrast, and balance are organized to convey specific information or emotions. Therefore, an image is not just a reproduction of a scene or event; it also engages the viewer through the arrangement of visual elements and interactive methods. Here is an example to illustrate this complexity:

Table 4.27 A brief visual analysis of example 39

Example 39	
Time range	00:15-00:20
Visual process	Action process and Symbolic process
Participant	The sun and The Great Wall
Interactive structures	Long shot and Low angle.
Composition	Top and Bottom, and Salience

This shot, extracted from the opening sequence of the video, captures the majestic scene of the sun gradually ascending over the Great Wall.

First, in terms of the representational meaning, the direction of the sun’s shining is an example of a non-transactional action structure. The Actor is the sun, and the directional force represents the orientation of its radiance. The sun is the most salient participant. The circumstance elements encompass the Great Wall, the mountains, the expansive sky, and the birds in flight. Given the absence of additional participants, it is categorized as a non-transactional process. Through the process, the audience can enjoy the magnificent scene of the sun slowly appearing from the Great Wall and rising into the sky. This shot also embodies the symbolic process. The sun serves as the primary participant, the Carrier, symbolizing hope, renewal, and vitality. Its upward movement suggests a new beginning or positive transformation, while its radiant light illuminates the scene, conveying warmth and optimism. The Great Wall, another key participant, represents China’s historical legacy, cultural resilience, and national identity. The scenic depiction, strategically positioned at the video’s outset, symbolizes China as a nascent sun, growing increasingly radiant and captivating. The background, with its gradient sky transitioning from deep blue to orange-red, enhances the symbolic meaning by representing a shift from darkness to light, further reinforcing the theme of progress and optimism.

Second, from the interactive meaning, the shot is taken a long shot and low angle. The use of a long shot captures the vastness of the scene, allowing both the natural and historical elements to be fully presented. This wide perspective immerses the viewer in a grand narrative, evoking a sense of awe and national pride. The low-angle shot further enhances the image's impact, making the Great Wall appear even more imposing and majestic while emphasizing the sun's brilliance and significance. This angle imbues the scene with a sense of reverence and solemnity, as if the audience is looking up at both nature and history with admiration. Overall, the image not only showcases the beauty of natural and cultural landscapes but also evokes a powerful sense of optimism, strength, and cultural pride, resonating with the viewer on both an emotional and intellectual level.

Third, from the compositional level, the shot adopts the top-bottom structure, creating a clear and impactful visual hierarchy. At the top of the frame, the sun dominates the scene, its vivid hues painting the sky brightly. The bright and intense colors give it high modality, drawing immediate attention and making it the most salient element of the composition. High modality in color signifies a strong visual presence and emotional intensity, reinforcing the sun's symbolic role as a source of light and new beginnings. At the bottom of the frame, the Great Wall of China stretches horizontally, grounding the image with its historical and cultural significance. The Wall's solid and imposing presence contrasts with the dynamic and radiant sun above, creating a balance between the natural and the man-made. This top-bottom structure not only organizes the visual elements spatially but also establishes a metaphorical relationship between the two: the sun represents the future and aspirations, while the Great Wall embodies resilience and heritage. Together, they form a cohesive narrative that evokes a sense of national pride and continuity. The salience principle is particularly evident in the way the sun's vibrant colors stand out against the landscape. This deliberate use of composition and salience guides the viewer's interpretation, emphasizing themes of renewal, strength, and cultural identity.

Such imagery captures the audience's attention but also sets a powerful tone, suggesting a nation on the rise, brimming with potential and promise. The visual

metaphor of the rising sun effectively draws the audience's eye, creating an immediate and lasting impression of a country that is both dynamic and awe-inspiring.

4.2 Modality Synergy in the Documentary

Although a single verbal or visual modality can convey meaning, multimodal synergy is not a simple superposition of two modalities. Because of their different characteristics, the combination of verbal modality and visual modality can spread information, construct narrative, and shape images more effectively through organic combination and ultimately gives full play to the advantages of the documentary. In a documentary, a kind of dynamic video form, the modalities, including text, image, sound, music, and other modes, work together to form a comprehensive meaning expression. If we only focus on one modality and ignore the synergy of the other modalities, it will not only weaken the overall narrative effect of the documentary but also fail to understand the advantages of its multimodality expression. Through the collaborative use of verbal and visual modalities, documentaries can convey information more vividly, express emotions more deeply, and shape national images more comprehensively, thus effectively enhancing their communication influence and realizing the multi-dimensional display and positive communication of national images.

The meaning of images is always related to and, in a sense, dependent on verbal text (Roland Barthes et al., 1967). The purpose of this chapter is to explore how verbal and visual modalities work together to construct meaning, especially in multimodal discourse such as a documentary. When discussing how verbal and visual modalities cooperate to construct meaning, this paper mainly focuses on analyzing the cooperative relationship between them, especially the complementary relationship between modalities. To focus on this core issue, this paper will not discuss in detail the interaction of verbal and visual modalities in non-complementary relationships.

4.2.1 Reinforcement Relation

In multimodal discourse, it is common for a single modality to fall short in fully conveying its intended meaning, thus relying on additional modalities for support. This

relationship is termed complementary, while others are classified as non-complementary (Zhang Delu, 2009). Within complementary relationships, it is crucial to differentiate between those that involve reinforcement and those that do not. A reinforcement relationship occurs when one modality takes on the dominant role in communication while additional modalities serve to enhance or supplement the primary message. Here are some specific examples to further elaborate:

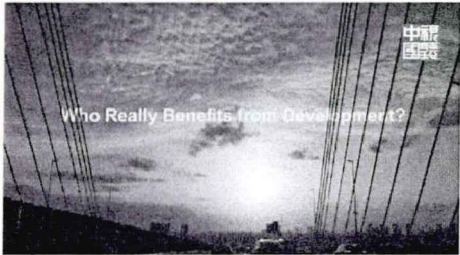
Table 4.28 The example of the reinforcement relation

Verbal Modality	I am going to take you on a journey through five major areas: the political system, economy, science and innovation, ecology, and people’s livelihood.	
Visual Modality		
Time range	01:01-01:02	01:05-01:06
Relation	Reinforcement relation	

This example is taken from the opening introduction of the documentary. In this example, the main information is expressed through the verbal modality. Without the narration, the audience cannot interpret the visual modality’s abstract content. Its meaning remains inaccessible unless the audience refer to the accompanying narrative. The narration acts as a key tool for unlocking the visual modality’s significance.

The text of this part is highly abstract, representing five key aspects of contemporary China: the political system, economy, science and innovation, ecology, and people’s livelihood. Within the verbal modality, the clause encodes a material process, as evidenced by the verbal phrase that foregrounds a deliberate, purposeful action performed by the speaker. The Actor is explicitly marked as “I,” which positions the speaker as the authoritative agent guiding the action, while “you” functions as the Goal, positioning the audience as recipients of this guided exploration. The spatial metaphor “on a journey through five major areas” functions as a spatial circumstance, framing the abstract exploration of these topics as a physical movement. By employing a material process, the speaker constructs a sense of active agency and authoritative guidance, reinforcing his role as a narrator who leads the audience through the discourse. In the visual modality, both images belong to action processes. The actor is the host of the documentary. All the images function as offer images, providing supplementary information to the audience, so they are the offer acts. Social distance is mainly the long shot because it shows the full figure of the host, offering an objective attitude. This is also in line with the documentary’s objective narrative characteristics and increases the credibility. From the perspective of modality synergy, the audience will not understand the meaning of the visual modality. The verbal modality is the main form of communication in the foreground, and images assist the audience to understand.

Table 4.29 The example of the reinforcement relation

Verbal Modality	Who really benefits from development?
Visual Modality	
Time range	02:06-02:10
Relation	Reinforcement relation

This image is from the introduction part of the documentary, and it starts with a question to keep the audience interested and thinking. The documentary expands on the meaning of the narration by showing China's city life and the rising sun in pictures.

From the perspective of representational function and ideational function, the image is a symbolic process. The sun is the carrier. It can be seen that the sun is salient in the representation by being placed in the foreground through exaggerated size. So, the sun is conventionally associated with symbolic values, such as hope, common prosperity, and development. In the clause, the question employs a material process, as indicated by the verb "benefits". The actor is interrogative, "who", leaving the beneficiary unstated, which greatly captures the audience's interest and curiosity.

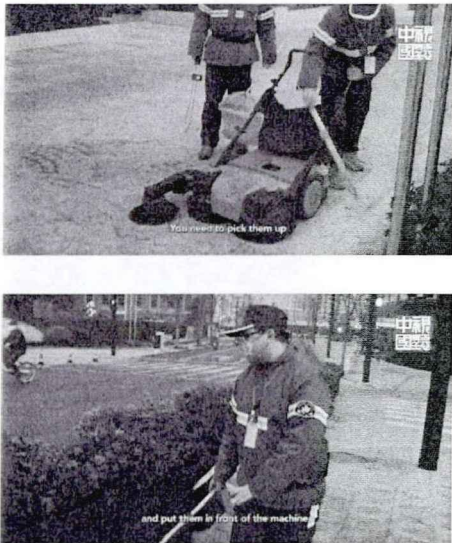
From the perspective of interactive function and interpersonal function, the sun occupies most of the image. The close-up view of the picture is conducive to narrowing the psychological distance between the audience and inspiring emotional resonance at the personal level. There are no obvious modal verbs in the sentence, such as may, might, should and so on, so the modality is neutral, indicating that the speaker is stating the question in an objective way, without attaching subjective judgment or speculation. In the sentence, it is an interrogative mood. The function of the interrogative is to seek information or arouse the audience's thinking, which reflects the interaction between the speaker and the audience.

From the compositional function, in the picture, the sun occupies a large area, taking the structure from center to margin. The element of the sun is emphasized. It can be seen the color of the sun is very bright, which is more salient. The main modality is the verbal modality, the narration, which introduces the important question and arouses the audience's curiosity.

4.2.2 Non-Reinforcement Relation

The non-reinforcement highlights that the two modalities are equally vital and interdependent. The two modalities are indispensable in the expression of meaning, and the lack of either mode will cause incomplete meaning.

Table 4.30 The example of the non-reinforcement relation

Verbal Modality	You need to pick them up and put them in front of the machine.
Visual Modality	
Time range	13:25-13:27
Relation	Non-reinforcement relation

The image depicts a sanitation worker and the host engaging in collaborative street cleaning. From the perspective of representational function, the sanitation worker and the host function as active participants in an action process. The cleaning tools in their hands form vectors that visually bridge their interaction. This constructs a dynamic narrative of collaborative labor. The verbal modality constructs meaning through three meta-functions: ideationally, the clause foregrounds a material process, positioning “you” as the actor responsible for manipulating inanimate goals “them”. The lack of explicit circumstantial detail abstracts the action. The representational process of the image complements the missing information of the verbal modality.

From the perspective of interactive function, the actors do not look directly at the camera but focus on their work, which creates a sense of distance between the observer and the observed and enhances the authenticity of the narrative. As for the social distance, the image is a medium shot, which shows the frontline worker’s movements while preserving the environmental background. This distance is neither too distant nor too intimate, allowing the audience to look at their work details and the working

environment while maintaining a certain space for reflection. The visual Angle of the image is horizontal, suggesting equality and respect and avoiding condescending sympathy or criticism. Interpersonally, the declarative mood positions the sentence as a statement. There are no explicit modal verbs in this sentence, and the audience can see that the frontline worker here is telling the host about their daily work.

From the compositional function and textual function, the two shots are in the center to margin structure. In the first shot, the cleaning machine is located in the center of the image and becomes the visual focus, attracting the audience's attention. In the other shot, the frontline worker is in the center of the image. The cleaning machine is in a very bright orange, and the clothes worn by the sanitation worker and the host are in a bright dark blue, which is very striking compared to the surrounding environment. Textually, the unmarked topical theme "you" positions the reader as the starting point of the directive, and the new information is the direction. The conjunction word "and" connects two short clauses.

The visual modality shows the specific scene of the frontline worker conveying the specific work. The visual modality and verbal modality support each other in conveying the same theme and form meaning enhancement. The visual modality conveys the specific working conditions of the workers through the image, which visualizes the scene and the action and transmits an equal attitude. The verbal modality is explained to the audience in detail. The visual and verbal modalities do not repeat the same information, but each carries different meanings, and both are indispensable. Together, the verbal and visual modalities construct a cohesive multimodal narrative. This combination reveals China's frontline workers' working situation and the large population of migrants.

In conclusion, as two different modalities of expression, verbal and visual modalities have their unique functions and characteristics. The verbal modality can accurately convey complex concepts and information with its abstractness and logic. Images, on the other hand, are intuitive and emotional, which can quickly attract attention and arouse the audience's resonance. The organic combination of the two can realize the superposition and enhancement of meaning through the complementary

relationship to convey information more effectively, construct a narrative, and deepen the audience's understanding and feelings. This kind of complementary relationship is not only reflected in the mutual complement of meaning but also in the strengthening of emotional expression and the optimization of information transmission.

This combination not only realizes the unity of concrete and abstract, making the information transmission more accurate and profound, but also makes up for the limitations of a single modality and significantly improves the coherence and expressiveness of the narrative. At the same time, the interaction between language and images further amplifies the emotional resonance and makes the audience more immersed in the narrative. Finally, this multi-modal expression successfully constructs multi-level meaning and reveals the deep connotations.

4.3 China's National Image in the Documentary

Documentaries have natural advantages in telling Chinese stories and spreading Chinese voices. Compared with books and other forms of artistic expression of the single modality, the multimodalities form of the documentary can build a true and comprehensive national image. Documentaries, with their authenticity and appeal combined with multimodalities, have become an important tool for spreading Chinese stories and shaping the national image.

China on the Move (Season 2) elects the successful experiences in various areas of China in the past decade and brings together the views of Chinese government officials, experts, and scholars at home and abroad. It adopts all sectors of society with vivid stories to tell how the government, people, enterprises, and all sectors of society have dealt with various difficulties and tests in the process of China's development. The documentary focuses on China's action and value orientation to solve practical problems and shows China's national temperament and great responsibility in dealing with various problems. By presenting China's development achievements, development experience, and contributions to global issues in an objective and vivid way, it can transcend cultural differences and arouse emotional resonance among global audiences.

The perception of a national image is holistic but not one-dimensional; rather, it is multidimensional. The most critical dimensions that shape a national image are the governmental dimension and the citizen dimension and so on. (Fan Hong and Hu Yu, 2016).

4.3.1 The Happy and Prosperous People

By lifting over 770 million people out of poverty since the 1970s, including the final 100 million in the last eight years leading up to 2020, China has achieved a historic milestone in eradicating extreme poverty. The rural revitalization initiative, which began in 2000, has further driven sustainable development in rural areas, resulting in significant economic growth. These efforts have not only improved material living standards but also enriched cultural and social life, as evidenced by villagers singing and dancing at festivals. The government’s commitment to rural revitalization and poverty alleviation has created a society that values both material well-being and emotional fulfillment. Together, these achievements have shaped a national image of China as a country where the people live happily and healthily, society is stable and harmonious, and the government is trusted and effective.

Table 4.31 The example of the happy and prosperous people

Verbal modality	We sanitation workers all feel honored. The villages’ revenue increased by 40% from the previous year, and villagers’ incomes continue to grow. We sing and dance like this at festivals. This is what this village should be like. We feel happy and satisfied.
Visual modality	
Time range	07:13-07:14

The ideational function highlights the people as active beneficiaries of government policies, experiencing both emotional satisfaction and tangible economic improvements. Mental processes such as “feel honored,” “feel happy,” and “feel satisfied” emphasize their emotional responses, while material processes like “increased by 40%” and “continue to grow” underscore the tangible economic progress achieved in the villages. Behavioral processes “sing and dance” reflect cultural and social activities that signify happiness and community cohesion. Temporal circumstances like “from the previous year” and “at festivals” provide context for these improvements, portraying a direct cause-and-effect relationship between government actions and the people’s enhanced quality of life. From the perspective of representational meaning, the image functions as an action process, where the participants (the villagers and the British host) are engaged in a shared moment of joy and connection. Their smiles and the act of holding hands symbolize happiness, unity, and cultural exchange, visually reinforcing the idea of a harmonious and satisfied community.

The interpersonal function further reinforces this image through the use of positive language and a confident tone. Declarative statements like “we all feel honored” and “we feel happy and satisfied” reflect the people’s confidence in their improved circumstances and their trust in the government. Positive words such as “honored,” “happy,” “satisfied,” and “increased by 40%” convey a favorable evaluation of their current situation and the government’s role in achieving it. The phrase “this is what this village should be like” expresses a sense of fulfillment and alignment with the people’s expectations, further reinforcing their satisfaction. The declarative mood used throughout presents the people’s feelings and achievements as factual and undeniable, constructing them as confident and content. From the perspective of interactive meaning, the image is a demand image, as the participants’ gaze at the audience creates a sense of engagement and connection. This gaze invites the audience to share in their happiness and satisfaction, fostering an emotional bond between the audience and the subjects. The smiles and joyful expressions of the participants convey a positive and welcoming attitude, reinforcing the textual message of contentment.

The textual function organizes the information into a coherent narrative, emphasizing the people's happiness, economic progress, and cultural vitality. The theme is consistently "we" (the people), positioning them as the central focus of the discourse, while the rhemes, such as "feel honored," "increased by 40%," and "sing and dance," highlight their emotional and economic improvements. New information, such as a "40% increase in revenue" and "sing and dance at festivals," is placed at the end of clauses, drawing attention to the people's achievements and happiness. Temporal cohesion markers like "from the previous year" and "at festivals" create a clear context for the improvements and celebrations, while logical cohesion markers like "and" connect the people's emotional responses with their economic and social activities, forming a unified narrative. From the perspective of compositional meaning, the image is structured to emphasize harmony and balance. The villagers and the British host are centrally positioned, creating a focal point that draws the audience's attention to their joyful interaction. The balanced arrangement of the participants, along with their physical connection (holding hands), symbolizes unity and cooperation. The background, depicting the village environment, provides context without distracting from the main subjects, further emphasizing the villagers' connection to their community and their pride in their achievements.

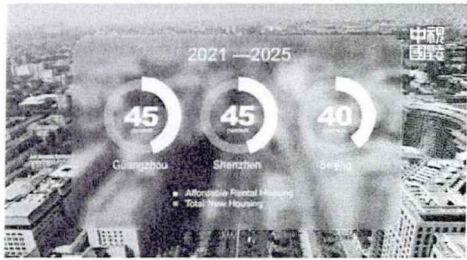
In conclusion, the verbal and visual modalities create a cohesive narrative that portrays the Chinese people as happy and satisfied. The text provides the factual and emotional foundation, detailing the economic progress and emotional well-being of the people, while the image adds a human and relatable dimension, visually capturing their joy and unity. The synergy between the two modalities reinforces the message of happiness and satisfaction, with the text's declarative statements and positive lexis aligning with the image's joyful and engaging depiction. This multimodal interplay constructs a powerful and persuasive narrative that showcases the Chinese people's improved livelihoods and their emotional fulfillment, ultimately portraying a society that is both economically prosperous and emotionally content.

4.3.2 The Efficient and Capable Government

In international communication, the government is the representative of the country, so the government image, to a large extent, has become the primary representative of the national image. (Fan Hong and Hu Yu, 2016).

Under the leadership of the Communist Party of China (CPC), the world’s largest developing country has achieved a complete eradication of extreme poverty. The documentary meticulously constructs the image of the Chinese government as efficient and capable by highlighting its concrete actions, measurable achievements, and strategic planning. Through detailed accounts of initiatives such as balancing competing interests and affordable housing programs, the government is portrayed as an entity capable of setting and achieving ambitious goals. By balancing competing interests and integrating new employment styles into traditional systems, the government is depicted as adaptable and forward-thinking. This combination of textual and visual modalities creates a compelling narrative of a government that is not only capable of delivering tangible results but also deeply committed to addressing the needs of its citizens.

Table 4.32 The example of the efficient and capable government

Verbal modality	China claims to have lifted around 770 million people out of poverty. By 2020, Shanghai claimed 130,000 affordable rental apartments on its books for a total investment of over 20 billion yuan. The authorities are attempting to balance competing interests here, trying to integrate new styles of employment into a system that is traditionally focused on classical work systems.
Visual modality	 The infographic displays three circular progress indicators for the years 2021–2025. The first circle for Guangzhou shows a goal of 45%. The second circle for Shenzhen shows a goal of 45%. The third circle for Beijing shows a goal of 40%. A legend indicates that the solid grey area represents 'Affordable Rental Housing' and the dotted grey area represents 'Total New Housing'.
Time range	14:58-15:08

First, in terms of the ideational function, the text highlights China as the primary actor, taking concrete actions such as “lifting around 770 million people out of poverty” and “address housing and employment challenges”. Participants such as “China” and “the authorities” are positioned as the agents of change, while the beneficiaries implied to be the general public, particularly those in need of affordable housing and new employment opportunities, are the focus of these efforts. Material processes like “bring” and “account for” emphasize the government’s tangible actions, while relational processes such as “is” and “are attempting” underscore its plans and efforts to balance competing interests. Temporal circumstances like “by 2020,” “by 2025,” and “from 2021 to 2025” highlight the government’s ability to set and work toward long-term goals, while quantitative circumstances such as “130,000 affordable rental apartments,” “over 20 billion yuan,” and “600,000 apartments” provide precise details, reflecting the government’s focus on measurable outcomes. This ideational structure portrays the government as an active, goal-oriented entity that takes concrete steps to address societal needs. From the perspective of representational meaning, the table shows the percentages of the affordable rental housing in three big cities. They belong to the same category, and three cities all belong to the same overarching category, so the shot belongs to the classificational process.

Second, the interpersonal function further reinforces this image through the use of positive language and a confident tone. The declarative mood, as seen in statements like “Shanghai claimed 130,000 affordable rental apartments” and “the ambitious aim is to bring this to 600,000 apartments by 2025,” reflects the government’s confidence in its ability to achieve these goals. Positive lexis such as “ambitious aim,” “affordable rental housing,” and “balance competing interests” conveys a favorable evaluation of the government’s efforts, while the phrase “attempting to balance competing interests” acknowledges the complexity of the task while framing the government as proactive and solution-oriented. This interpersonal framing constructs the government as confident, capable, and committed to addressing complex challenges. From the interactive meaning, the image is an offer image, presenting factual information for the

audience to interpret. The lack of direct engagement reinforces the objective and authoritative nature of the data.

Third, the textual function organizes the information into a coherent narrative. The theme is consistently “Shanghai” and “the authorities,” positioning the government as the central focus of the discourse. The rhemes, such as “claimed 130,000 affordable rental apartments,” highlight the government’s actions and goals, while new information like “130,000 affordable rental apartments” and “600,000 apartments by 2025” is strategically placed at the end of clauses to draw attention to these achievements. Temporal cohesion markers like “by 2020,” “by 2025,” and “from 2021 to 2025” create a clear timeline, emphasizing the government’s ability to plan and execute long-term strategies. Logical cohesion markers like “and” and “for” connect the government’s housing initiatives with its broader efforts to balance competing interests, forming a unified and persuasive narrative. From the compositional meaning, the three cities are arranged in a balanced and structured manner, symbolizing the government’s methodical approach, while the highlighted proportions draw attention to the ambitious yet achievable targets set by the government. The integration of text and the image ensures clarity and strengthens the connection between the visual and textual modalities.

In conclusion, the synergy between the verbal and visual modalities creates a cohesive narrative that portrays the Chinese government as efficient, and capable and committed to improving people’s livelihoods, reflecting a high sense of responsibility for its citizens. The text provides detailed information about the government’s goals and achievements, while the image visually represents the data, making the information more accessible and impactful. The image’s classificational process directly supports the textual claims about the government’s plans for affordable rental housing in first-tier cities, reinforcing the message through visual clarity and organization. Both modalities emphasize the government’s ability to set and achieve measurable goals, with the text highlighting specific targets and timelines and the image providing a visual representation of progress. The combination of detailed textual information and visually appealing data representation creates a powerful and persuasive narrative,

appealing to both logic and visual understanding. The text and image construct a compelling portrayal of the Chinese government as a capable and efficient entity committed to addressing complex societal challenges through systematic and transparent policies.

4.3.3 The United and Progressive Society

In the grand endeavor of China’s unity and progress, social organizations, government, enterprises, and the public work together in mutual support and collaboration, collectively gathering the powerful force to realize the Chinese Dream. Social organizations fully leverage their unique advantages, playing a bridging role that runs through the entire process and all areas of economic and social development. They effectively integrate resources, foster cooperation, and promote deep integration and shared progress among all sectors of society. This vivid practice not only highlights the traditional strengths of solidarity and mutual assistance in Chinese society but also showcases the spirit of joint efforts and shared development in the modern era, painting a magnificent picture of a society united in purpose and striving for greatness.

Table 4.33 The example of the united and progressive society

Verbal modality	The foundation is now working with a new partner in the village, telecom giant SAMSUNG group, making this a partnership between government, enterprise, and foundation. We must establish cooperatives that pool the resources of the whole village and utilize all the talents in the village.
Visual modality	
Time range	08:15-08:16

The image depicts a group of people sitting together, raising their cups and clinking them in the center. The image and text effectively demonstrate the collectivist nature and spirit of unity that characterize Chinese society.

In terms of the ideational function, the processes reveal a strong emphasis on collective action and shared responsibility. In the first sentence, the material process “is working” presents the foundation’s collaboration with a new partner, the telecom giant, the SAMSUNG group. The accompanying circumstantial element “with” reflects the collaborative effort between these entities. The second clause employs a relational process, defining the relationship and roles of the participants. The sentence contains a material process, “must establish,” as its primary process, indicating a deliberate action to create collective organizations. The use of material and relational processes, along with the accompanying circumstance, highlights the emphasis on joint activities and equal roles, reinforcing the ideological significance of unity and cooperation in this context.

From the perspective of representational meaning, the image realizes the action and symbolic processes. The reached-out arms of the participants are the vectors, and the participants are the individuals gathered around the table. In terms of the symbolic process, the act of clinking glasses and the surrounding participants serve as carriers of deeper meaning. The clinking of glasses symbolizes agreement, celebration, and solidarity, while the circular seating arrangement conveys equality, inclusiveness, and a sense of collective spirit. The central focal point created by the clinking glasses reinforces the idea of a shared objective, while the circular formation visually represents harmony and unity. These visual elements embody the cultural values of collectivism, emphasizing the importance of group cohesion and mutual effort. Through both the action and symbolic processes, the image effectively communicates themes of unity, collaboration, and collective purpose, reflecting the spirit of collectivism.

From the interpersonal meaning, the first sentence, with a declarative clause, presents the partnership as factual. The second sentence shifts to an imperative mood with “must,” expressing persuasion and obligation. Positive appraisal of cooperatives

(“pool resources,” “utilize talents”) reinforces the proposal’s value. These strategies establish authority, urgency, and inclusivity, aiming to persuade the audience to accept and support the initiatives. In this image, the interactive meaning is constructed through the use of an offer image and a medium shot. As an offer image, the scene invites the audience to observe and interpret the collective action of the group. The medium shot frames the participants from the waist up, allowing the audience to see their gestures, facial expressions, and interactions clearly and capture the spatial arrangement of the group. The participants’ smiles and eye contact with each other further enhance the sense of mutual engagement. Through these visual elements, the image communicates a strong sense of collective spirit and cooperation, inviting the audience to recognize and appreciate the values of unity and collaboration.

The compositional meaning of the image is constructed through the arrangement of visual elements to convey symbolic meanings. The composition, with participants seated around a central point, symbolizes unity, equality, and inclusiveness, as no single individual dominates the frame.

This section analyzes the keywords’ frequency in the English text of *China on the Move* (Season 2) through the corpus tool Ant Conc 4.3.1. The words “China” and “village” rank first and second, followed by terms such as “workers,” “urban,” and “rural.” These high-frequency words reflect the close connection between the Chinese government and its people, and China particularly focuses on livelihood issues. Through rural revitalization, the government is committed to ensuring that all people share in the benefits of economic development, with an emphasis on rural areas. It also addresses the complex issues arising from urbanization. Additionally, verbs frequently paired with “China” include “address,” “share,” and “launch,” indicating concrete actions. This demonstrates the government’s commitment to facing and addressing various challenges that arise during development. In the process of rapid economic growth, the government strives to balance efficiency and fairness, as well as development and livelihood, finding the equilibrium point to improve the living standards of the Chinese people.

Third, Chinese society is united and progressive. Emphasizing collectivism over individualism, Chinese society fosters collaboration among various stakeholders. For instance, the foundation has partnered with the telecom giant SAMSUNG Group, creating a collaboration between the government, enterprises, and the foundation. Similarly, villagers in rural areas work together, pooling their resources and talents to achieve rural revitalization and social progress. This collective effort reflects the broader societal commitment to shared goals, showcasing the vitality of a united and forward-moving Chinese society.

By weaving together personal stories and national initiatives, the documentary constructs a cohesive and compelling narrative. It portrays China as a place where individuals are happy and prosperous, the government is efficient and capable, and the society is united and progressive. This multidimensional approach not only humanizes the broader achievements but also reinforces the image of China as a harmonious, progressive, and globally respected country.

Chapter Five Conclusion

5.1 Research Findings

Through the in-depth analysis of chapter four, the main findings are as follows:

First, a detailed analysis of the verbal and visual modalities in the documentary is conducted. It is found that the most prevalent processes are the material process and relational process, with material processes accounting for 61%. Material processes are primarily used to introduce China's targeted poverty alleviation strategy and the affordable rental houses. Relational processes mainly highlight the arduous tasks, the living conditions of sanitation workers, and the concerns of freelance workers. From the interpersonal function, it primarily adopts a declarative tone to narrate the Chinese story, but it also contains an interrogative tone to ask questions from the viewpoint of the audience. For example, can the Chinese share the fruits of development? which can not only arouse the audience's attention and interest but also introduce China's major development issues and strategies. In terms of the textual function, the unmarked theme is highly adopted, which can better help the audience understand the Chinese story and reduce the cognitive load.

The visual modality complements and reinforces the verbal modality in conveying meaning. In the representational sense, narrative processes appear relatively frequently. The action process is mainly used to represent busy cityscapes as well as people's daily lives and work. The reactional process is characterized by interviews with many local and international experts, as well as interviews with ordinary people from all walks of life in China. In the interactive sense, the predominance of the offer image aims to provide some information, such as the economic development, the changes in the villages, and improvements in housing for urban migrants, etc. In addition, the documentary adopts a lot of medium and long shots to objectively present the practices of the Chinese people's sharing of development achievements and integrates the grand theme into the individual narrative. The documentary uses long shots to show the development of an entire region, natural scenery, and urban landscape. It is interspersed

with a large number of medium shots depicting the lives of ordinary people. The close-up shots are used to portray the details of the participants in the pictures, such as the facial expressions of the villagers, attempting to establish an interpersonal relationship with the audience. The video adopts a lot of eye-level angles to establish an equal relationship with the audience.

From the perspective of multimodal synergy, the verbal and visual modalities in the documentary exhibit a complementary relationship, especially the non-reinforced relationship. The strengths of each modality are strategically leveraged to enhance the overall communicative impact. The verbal modality, with its precise and structured linguistic expressions, provides clear narrative frameworks about grand narratives and personal stories. The visual modality, through its vivid imagery and dynamic compositions, provides different information and evokes emotional resonance. This synergistic interplay not only enriches the narrative depth but also amplifies the emotional engagement of the audience, thereby significantly reinforcing the effectiveness of national image communication across both the cognitive and affective dimensions. By integrating the analytical clarity of verbal language with the emotive power of visual storytelling, the documentary achieves a more compelling and holistic portrayal of the national image.

Through a comprehensive analysis of the verbal and visual modalities, the study reveals that the documentary effectively showcases China's endeavors and accomplishments in advancing rural revitalization, ensuring social equity, and adapting to the emerging economic sector. The processes constitute the core elements of China's national image. Specifically, the documentary employs material and mental processes in the verbal modality, combined with action and classification processes in the visual modality, to construct a three-dimensional national image characterized by the happy and prosperous people, the efficient and capable government, and the united and progressive society. Furthermore, the use of accompanying circumstances and processes further reinforces the overall image of a united and progressive Chinese society.

5.2 Research Implications

This thesis employs multimodal discourse analysis to explore the national image in the *China on the Move (Season 2)*, which offers both theoretical value and practical contributions.

Theoretically, it provides some insights into the development of multimodal discourse analysis and offers some suggestions for its development in the analysis of dynamic videos. Practically, the study explores the synergy between verbal and visual modalities in the documentary, revealing strategies for national image construction through multimodal resources. The research helps provide guidance for telling China's story well and presenting an authentic national image. By integrating theory and practice, this research not only advances the field of multimodal discourse analysis but also offers practical implications for national image communication to some extent.

5.3 Limitations and Suggestions

Through the multimodal discourse analysis of the documentary *China on the Move (Season 2)*, this thesis advances research on the publicity documentary and enhances understanding of how the modalities effectively construct the national image. However, there are still some gaps in certain areas and several aspects for future exploration.

First of all, this study takes Episode 5 of *China on the Move (Season 2)* as its primary analytical subject, which centers on people's livelihood. The documentary series comprehensively addresses four other core themes: the political system, economy, science and innovation, and ecology, providing a more comprehensive portrayal of China. Due to the constraints of article length, time, and energy, the author is not able to study as many related videos in this documentary as possible. Therefore, this article primarily analyzes the theme of people's livelihood, but the other themes hold equal scholarly significance. Future academic endeavors could productively explore these additional dimensions to construct a more comprehensive representation of China's contemporary profile.

Second, this thesis primarily analyzes the verbal and visual modalities in the documentary. However, as a dynamic video, other modalities, such as music also play a very important role in the construction of meaning. Due to the limitations of the author's knowledge, these aspects are not analyzed in this article. More attention should be paid to the use of other modalities, as well as to the formal characteristics of the modalities and the relationships between them in future studies. Most importantly, the modal synergy between them should be emphasized. It is hoped to conduct deeper and more comprehensive analyses of the corpus.

Third, the analysis and statistics of the verbal and visual modalities in this article are primarily conducted with the assistance of UAM Corpus Tool 6 and Elan 6.9 software. However, due to manual annotation, some mistakes could inevitably occur. In the future, more advanced multimodal discourse analysis annotation tools are needed to make the research results more objective and accurate. There should be clearer criteria and more specific examples when multimodal labelling is carried out. More advanced corpus software can be used in the future to improve the accuracy of the labelling; and lastly, scholars in the future can pay more attention to the Interrater reliability. Judgement was reached and agreed upon by another observer reviewing the same data to ensure that the analytical materials are comprehensive to enhance the credibility of the final analysis and contribute to the whole national image of China.

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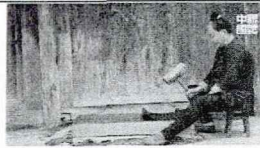
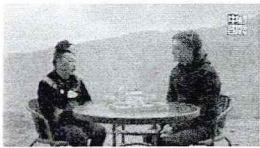
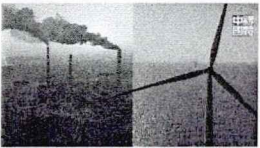
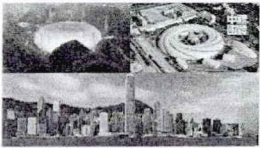
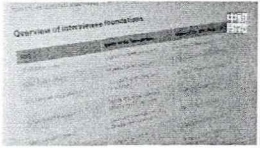
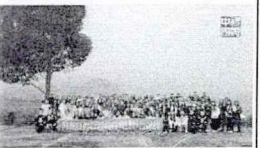
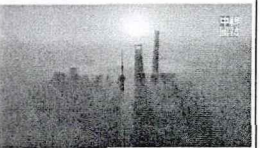
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Appendix: The List of the Photos

Representation Meaning			
			
			
			
			
Interactive Meaning			
			
			
			

Appendix: The List of the photos

			
Compositional Meaning			
			
Modality Analysis			
			
		